

Block**4****DEVELOPMENT COMMUNICATION: EMERGING
TRENDS**

UNIT 15
Development Communication: Emerging Trends

UNIT 16
Social & Behavioural Change Communication

UNIT 17
SBCC: Case Studies

UNIT 18
Alternative Media



UNIT 15 DEVELOPMENT

COMMUNICATION: EMERGING TRENDS

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15.0 INTRODUCTION

Development is a state activity which is reflected in its programmes and policies. In a welfare state, an elected government is under obligation to plan and take measures for development in social, economic, political and other spheres. Despite state being in the centre of development activities, there has been a debate since the later part of 20th century on the role and responsibilities of a government. Alongside, deliberations have been alive on the vitality of communication for development.

Another pertinent issue which is being debated intensely particularly in this century is the role of the people and the media in the process of development. Scholars have come out with so many approaches and models while defining development as a composite activity undertaken by the state with the help of the community and the mass media. Thus, the discipline of development communication has seen the evolution of two major trends - one that depends on the mass media to initiate large scale actions and another that involves participation of the community.

In this Unit, we shall discuss the models and paradigms of development communication and the participatory communication approach in development. We shall also discuss the role of advocacy and social marketing in pushing the process of development and attaining development goals.

15.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After going through this Unit, you should be able to do the following:

- Understand the role of communication in the process of development;
- Describe the paradigms and models of development communication;
- Appreciate the participation of the people in development programmes and policies;
- Comprehend the vitality of media technologies in development and taking the beneficiaries along;
- To figure out the role of advocacy in pushing the development agenda and the contribution of voluntary organisations; and
- To illustrate the usefulness of social marketing tools in creating awareness on the issues of development and achieving the goals.

15.2 PARADIGMS AND MODELS OF DEVELOPMENT COMMUNICATION

MacBride (1980) noted that earlier models of development communication used communication mainly for disseminating information amongst the people. These models were based on the hypothesis that as long as the development needs of the people are defined, necessary action can be executed at all levels in the society using a top down approach. However, these efforts could not achieve desired results.

The philosophy behind these models was that the same strategies of development employed in developed states could be replicated in developing or under-developed states, only by disseminating the knowledge and technology in those states. This is also referred to as the paradigm of modernisation. These early efforts were primarily focused on large scale usage of mass media for information transmission and audience persuasion and aimed at increased economic productivity.

15.2.1 Innovation Dissemination Model

Innovation dissemination model was considered important since it had a major influence on communication practices in the area of educational development.

This model was based on a theory proposed by Everett Rogers in 1962.

The innovation dissemination model was developed in the context of disseminating information to farmers in agricultural practices. The main components of this theory included

- a. the target population of the innovation
- b. the innovation for transmission
- c. the sources
- d. the communication channels

This model was often heavily criticised on the grounds that it failed to take into account varied kinds of target populations (the farmers in this case) and the ground realities of the socio-economic and political structures that could influence the ability to adopt new practices. The framework of vertical, top-down communication also lacked the mention of horizontal communication amongst the stakeholders themselves as well as any form of bottom-up communication on the part of those affected.

15.2.2 Participatory Communication Model

Over the last few decades, development and communication models have evolved significantly. New perspectives and practices have emerged following the massive use of media technologies for development processes. While the modernisation paradigm was criticised, a new model of development communication emerged keeping in mind the endogenous nature of development- the participatory communication model.

Rogers (1976) claimed that development is a global process based on local factors. In this process, societies are considered responsible and not the external factors coming from outside.

It can only be achieved through the active participation of those whose development is the key concern.

15.2.3 Paradigm of 'Dependence'

Understanding about the role of communication in development has also changed significantly over the years. The role of communication in the process of development is increasingly becoming more dynamic with the availability of new technology for the purpose of transmission. This has given a boost to participatory communication within the grass root community.

The modernisation model acknowledged this power of communication. But, it was observed that simply the use of mass media for disseminating information did not lead to any development in underdeveloped countries. It became clear that the development of the industrialised countries was conditional; it was based on the poor state of development in the Third World countries- that is the 'centre' was developing only at the expense of those in the 'periphery'.

So, a new phenomenon is referred here; this is known as the paradigm of 'dependence'. It indicates that the primary hindrances to development are not internal but external- that is the capitalist ideology propagated by the western

countries. Instead of becoming agents of change, the biased mass media messages become the causes for underdevelopment in the Third World.

15.2.4 Consciousness Model

Another important model arising from this paradigm that has revolutionised the field of development communication is Paolo Freire's (1973) consciousness model. This model identified communication as an inseparable element from political and social processes of development.

Freire contested the theory that only disseminating information or transferring knowledge to a passive receiver could bring about a change. He argued that development communication would be effective only when it looks beyond providing technical knowledge and skills and focuses more on raising awareness and approaching the developmental issues at the root. According to him, only individuals with independent and critical mind have the capability of influencing the people and bringing about a change in the society.

In *The Pedagogy of the Oppressed* (1973), Freire explains how people at the grassroots use development communication as a tool to make them aware of the issues of development. These people use communication as a means to organise and mobilise resources for collectively responding to these issues. Communication can be the key to help understand the depth of the issues and find concrete solutions that are sustainable in the long run.

Even Freire's model was criticised on the grounds of having a limited approach in terms of politicisation of developmental issues and the different repercussions it may lead to in developed countries and developing countries. Many suggested that instead of using politicisation as an approach, one based on education might be better as it would not cause confrontation but can facilitate the necessary course of action.

15.2.5 Paradigm of 'Another Development'

Another paradigm that emerged in the field of development communication is commonly known as the "paradigm of another development". It emphasised on the development of values and cultures over material development.

This paradigm emphasised on participatory communication at the grassroots level in the form of localised community media networks. Such communication could effectively mobilise the community to identify their own developmental issues, collectively determine solutions and adopt necessary activities to fulfill them.

As per a study of UNESCO, this approach indicates that people formulate their own problems and acquire an awareness of new options instead of letting a plan imposing on them that was formulated elsewhere. This, it becomes possible to intervene more effectively in the real space of the individual or the group (Berrigan, 1981). The internal horizontal communication and interactivity amongst the community members, with the community media as the operational instrument, facilitates the circulation of fundamental knowledge and understanding of issues.

15.2.6 Community Media Model

In community media model, communication activities act as elements of support for the development project and aim to build understanding and consensus amongst all the participants at all levels. Different points of view of different stakeholders are taken into consideration for holistic results and the solutions are mobilised at the grassroots level. The methodology consists of using tools and techniques, and the needs of the community can be systematically analysed, monitored and evaluated with the help of these tools and techniques.

The community approach places utmost importance on the grassroots access to the communication process. That is why this approach is democratic and ensures social justice. In other words, by providing the most disadvantaged to take control over the process of development by using community media, it creates an alternative media space by resisting the mass media's control over the community in question.

15.2.7 Social Marketing Approach

In recent developments, the approaches stemming from social marketing must be taken into consideration to complete this discussion on major trends of development communication. For example, it was seen that in the movement against AIDS, apart from the creation of small groups and communities, the mass media was also used extensively. The extensive use of internet and its impact on information dissemination is considerably noteworthy. Every day, numerous projects are emerging which are using modern technology to circulate information, mobilise resources and take collective action.

15.2.8 Communication and Participation

Decades of experience in the area of development communication has proven the importance of communication in the process of development. Even amidst such diversity of approaches and orientations, there is still an agreement about the need to have grassroots participation for effective execution of developmental plans. Participatory communication plays a decisive role in the supporting development. A popular FAO (Food and Agriculture Organisation of the United States) slogan says, "There is no development without communication" (Balit, 1988).

The primary takeaway from these years of practice of development communication is that the mere dissemination of a new idea is not enough to bring about lasting change or promote development, and that the key participants in the process of development are the people at the grassroots. The subjects of development are the best determinants of their own development needs, solutions and methods of execution.

Thus, participation is the most vital component of development communication. Instead of a top down approach, a horizontal or bottom up approach is more effective and can lead to sustainable development.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. Explain the Consciousness Model.

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2. Discuss with example the Social Marketing approach to development.

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3. “There is no development without communication” explain in terms of Communication and Participation.

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15.3 PARTICIPATORY COMMUNICATION APPROACH

The recent trends in development communication have precipitated a change in the paradigm by putting more focus on participation and empowerment. This perspective works on the premise that the recipients of development cannot just be passive audiences, instead they have to be the active participants in the process of development.

There have been many studies which emphasise on the participatory approach. Many scholars have reinforced the importance of receivers in development process stating that they should act as active agents.

Participatory development paradigm cannot be called a unified system; instead it is a system that aims to correct different theories and models of development process by insisting on the concept of empowerment. The scholars of this system do not portray themselves as the elements of great theories like modernisation and dependency theories.

15.3.1 Imperativeness of Communication for Participation

It is mentioned by Paulo Mefalopulos that communication is the backbone if one wants participation in the process of development. Participatory communication emphasises on the importance of dialogic communication. In this communication, a horizontal flow is maintained which is based on the sharing of perception of knowledge.

In the new concept of modernisation paradigm, communication flow is from top to bottom. So, it is considered different from the previously existing participatory communication. Even the messages in the process of mass communication are to be derived from the people who are vital in the process of development and not from any other source especially the authoritative source.

15.3.2 Empowerment of Receivers Essential for Participation

The UNDP annual report (1993) authenticates that the participation requires not only an increased control but also insists on an increased empowerment. Flow of information plays an important role in the participatory communication. In an ideal situation, it should preferably be horizontal flow and not in any other way.

The concept of awareness, as propagated by Brazilian scholar Paulo Friere, underlines that awareness enables the poor about their own situations which is reflected in their action. This theory is considered significant since it is considered to have inspired the theory of participatory communication.

Another concept that is relevant here is that of capability deprivation. This concept has been mooted by noted economist Amartya Sen who treats poverty not merely as an issue of lack of income but also a social issue.

The concept of participatory communication helps in understanding the process and the programmes of health communication. In participatory communication model, horizontal flow of communication and dialogue has a critical role, and so the relation between empowerment, communication and participation becomes quite important.

Here, the exchange of knowledge among people treating them as source and their participation in the process of communication are considered essential for development. The role of people in the empowering process is also a crucial factor in determining the direction of development. This model very clearly explains that it is the people who hold the center in the process of communication and not the technological aspect or infrastructural system.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. In brief explain the Participatory Communication Approach.

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2. People are the center in the process of communication. Comment.

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15.4 ADVOCACY AND COMMUNICATION FOR DEVELOPMENT

Advocacy is a dynamic collection of communicative activities that are undertaken in a directional way to help or propagate a school of thought or a cause to influence and attract attention of people, organisations and authorities.

In the socio-economic, politico-development context, the aim of advocacy is public welfare, where through concentrated advocacy, a group tries to draw the attention of the authorities, social groups, civic societies, NGOs, journalists and other individuals holding position of power and influence to create or amend the existing laws, policies, regulations so to make the lives of people better and to be able to adapt to the changing world scenarios.

15.4.1 Advocacy as a Means for Change

The basic objective of advocacy is to bring about a change in the society particularly poor people belonging to the lower strata. By pro-poor advocacy efforts are made to drive political decisions and draw attention of the authorities towards people categorised as poor and bring in light the struggles they face. Pursuing the goal of equitable and pro-poor approach, advocacy groups define advocacy as a means to bring about a change in the existing situations like:

- **ICT policies widening the gap between the rich and the poor:**

For example, “e-government” projects which bring public services to internet adversely affect those without internet access and hence reinforce the negative effects of digital divide.

- **ICT tools such as community based radio and television:**

Such tools are used keeping in mind, the economic affordability and the demography of the population for a mass reach and a greater impact.

- **Creation of centres as a part of pro-poor ICT access:**

Such centres are created for working on reducing the digital divide and adoption of mainstream good practices as participation in management and use of free and open source software.

15.4.2 Advocacy Approaches and Techniques

Advocacy is a two-way communication and the audience or the population at which advocacy communication is targeted at should be receptive and be ready to accept the change that is being advocated. It is important to create an “understanding” of welfare and the changes that are being advocated. Advocacy

is often faced with resistance and this resistance comes from political inertia, red-tapism and counter arguments from another more influential advocacy groups.

Effective advocacy, therefore, requires mapping and research to understand and guide through the political lobbies, interest groups and other key stakeholders. For instance, in the issues related to ICT policies the key stakeholders will include government departments, communication regulating authorities, telecommunication service providers, sector specific associations, media organisations and civil society interest groups.

Policy changes in a democratic set up usually takes time and is often debated and re-debated before it is actually put on paper and then implemented. Hence, effective and efficient advocacy has to include both long-term and short-term planning with both top-down and bottom-up approaches. It also includes heuristic intelligence and adapt accordingly with the willingness to form alliances with flexibility in approach.

15.4.3 Policy Monitoring and Public Accountability

The first step for effective policy related advocacy starts with assessing, canvassing and analysing the plans and implementation of the present policies in action. The assessment of plans related to development can be done by assessing

- a) the commitments to provide ICT infrastructure to people
- b) universal access policies for development
- c) support for community-based development units
- d) mechanisms to ensure proper implementation

Policy monitoring ensures accountability of the government particularly in a democratic setup. Public institutions can perform this job effectively by exerting pressure on elected governments. Policy monitoring by advocacy groups and other public interest institutions leads to transparency since reports published by such groups bring forward the truth and the loopholes of administration. This creates a pressure on the government for better implementation and action.

Policy monitoring may be in the form of independent investigation. It may consist of a standardised analysis at the beginning of a policy by checking its objectives and possible effects on people. It may also include a follow-up study to assess whether what is delivered was promised on paper or there is a gap between the execution and the plans.

The departments of the government, other bodies and regulatory organisations need to be sincere enough for policy monitoring and public accountability. These entities need to maintain and publish data and reports on a regular basis and undertake research and consultation to facilitate decision making in the public interest

In India for instance, every ministry publishes annual reports. Also, consultations are made with the people on policy in making by putting the draft on the website of PIB and inviting suggestions from the people. Though there is a lack of transparency if these suggestions are finally taken into account.

In a democratic country like India, policy monitoring can be done not only by advocacy groups but by common citizens as well by making use of the following tools.

- a) Seeking information from government agencies and departments by filing Right to Information (RTI) applications
- b) Scrutinising reports of government departments and authorities
- c) Lokpal, Lokayukta and other laws establishing accountability of the government towards the people

In countries where such system or laws are not available or easily accessible, the responsibility comes on the civil society and advocacy groups. Other than these, various tools like citizen surveys, social audits, policy reviews and investigative journalism have become effective tools to maintain social accountability.

15.4.4 Policy Dialogue – ICT and Mainstream Development Policy

Civil societies often want more say in governance as they consider themselves representatives of the people and want to be involved in the process of policy drafting from the first stage by engaging in a bidirectional communication with policy makers.

A robust and effective example of this is **India Against Corruption** movement popularly known as Anna Movement (2011) which was launched to put pressure on the government to bring Lok Pal (Ombudsman) Act for eradication corruption. This organisation compelled the then Government of India to consider their draft of the Lokpal legislation while enacting a law.

Another example is that of the Women of Uganda Network (WOUGNET). They have a programme on “gender and ICT policy advocacy” and their priorities include a focus on existing ICT policies. They also engage in policy development processes.

Engagement in discussions related to pro-poor ICT access can be gained deciding the key areas of development and their interrelation with it such as education, health and rural livelihoods. This process ultimately contributes to national development strategies.

15.4.5 Interventions and Campaigns for Policy Change

In India, social activists, journalists, retired civil servants lawyers, professionals and academicians instituted an organisation with the name of The National Campaign for People’s Right to Information (NCPRI) in 1996. The objective of this campaign was pushing for a central law for providing citizens a Right to Information. For drafting the right to information law deliberations continued for many years. Around the same time many states had also passed rights to information laws.

After years of discussions right to information law was passed by Indian Parliament as the Freedom of Information Act 2002. The Act could not be implemented for technical reasons, so pressure of civil society continued for having a transparency law. Finally, UPA 1 Government initiated the passage of the Right to Information Act in 2005.

It is difficult to achieve fast results through civil society campaigns for policy change. These campaigns and their leaders should have resilience and determination and should be goal-oriented to bring the desired change. Often, confrontational in nature, campaigning involves public demonstrations, lobbying and use of social and traditional media, letter writing and street protests. The conflict between civil societies and administration helps in gaining attention and public support.

Campaigns are usually built as a response to policy changes which cause the feelings of injustice or isolation amongst specific strata of population. The most appropriate example of this is Anti-CAA movement that was launched by the civil society in India to register their protest against the enactment of Citizenship Amendment Act 2019. This movement was finally called off in March 2020 in the wake of COVID- 19 with no substantial result.

International organisations such as Amnesty International and Greenpeace are known for innovative ways of campaigning. Over the years these organisations have demonstrated campaigning methods and the lessons learned from them are relevant to policy advocacy. These organisations have immensely contributed in two core areas of development – human rights and environment. Campaigning by Amnesty International and Greenpeace has affected policies in many democratic countries including India.

However, we also find such examples where even democratic governments do not like policy interventions due to different approaches on development issues. As per prevailing situation in 2020, Amnesty International and Greenpeace have practically closed their operations in India in view of excessive regulation and restrictions on their activities.

15.4.6 Building Advocacy Capacity of Stakeholder Groups

People from underprivileged sections of society face lack of resources and the consequent barriers in accessing information and their right to freedom of expression. It leads to their absence in being able to represent themselves on public forums. This ultimately deprives them advocating issues related to their development needs. This situation has formed the basis for pro-poor advocacy regarding access to development, and demands attention of civil societies and other advocacy groups.

As Drèze and Sen describe it: “One is assertion (or, more precisely, self-assertion) of the underprivileged through political organisations. The other is solidarity with the underprivileged on the part of other members whose interests and commitments are broadly linked and who are often better placed to advance the cause of the disadvantaged by virtue of their own privileges (e.g. formal education, access to the media, economic resources, political connections).”

Many pro-poor advocacy groups are managed by educated middle-class professionals who have never faced the issues they are advocating and hence, they pursue it only as a vocation. Though they have all the right intentions and social solidarity with the poor and their struggle, they show an inauthentic and biased representation of the issues they do not fully understand. They are backed by strong theoretical and conceptual framework but do not have the practical experience of the same.

Thus, simply doing advocacy for the poor and the underprivileged will not serve the purpose. More important is building the advocacy capacity of the underprivileged and disadvantaged sections in the form of self-help groups. Effective pro-poor advocacy must include strategies to achieve an increase in the voice and influence of the underprivileged sections of the society with regard to development oriented policy making.

Two examples can be cited here with regard to capacity building. Let us first look into the example of Deccan Development Society (DDS), a grassroots organisation working with women's sanghams (self-help groups) in about 75 villages of Medak district, Andhra Pradesh. This society comprised about five hundred women members who were mostly Dalit and belonged to the lowest strata of society. The women members of DDS chalked out a strategy for "autonomous communities" and formed a DDS Community Media Trust for this purpose. They set up a video production unit and Sangham Radio - the first rural community radio in India and the first women's radio in South Asia.

Another example is that of the Bangladesh NGOs Network for Radio and Communication (BNNRC). This national network combines a programme of advocacy in policy areas such as right to information, community broadcasting and e-governance. This network functioned with practical support from rural knowledge centres and community radio stations.

15.4.7 Pathfinder and Demonstrator Projects

Innovation and change in traditional policies are not easy to communicate and is often met by a lot of cognitive and functional barriers. Hence, one needs to build an argument based on examples.

"Pathfinder" or "demonstrator" projects can, therefore, be an effective strategy for policy advocacy. If success can be demonstrated through an example, it can have a major impact on increasing the demand and interest. Some small scale experiments can help in understanding the effectiveness of a particular model.

RITS was set up in Brazil in 1997 to strengthen communication capacity of civil society organisations. A demonstrator project launched by RITS in partnership with Sampa.org led to the establishment of 128 community-based telecentres in São Paulo, with an estimated half a million users per month.

The model offered free public access and training support. It was based on free and open source software, and promoted community involvement in management and development of the centres as a space for community organisation. This motivated the Brazilian government to invest further in this area.

Another example comes from Nigeria. The Nigeria Community Radio Coalition, launched in 2003, mobilised broad support for its campaign of setting community radio services in the country. It conducted a pilot scheme in at least six locations keeping in view the country's geopolitical zones. It was supported and funded by the National Broadcasting Commission and National Development Programme.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What are some commonly used advocacy techniques?

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2. What is the importance of policy monitoring?

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15.5 SOCIAL MARKETING APPROACH

The concept of social marketing is comparatively new as it was introduced only in the later part of 20th century. Initially, it was used for the purpose of promoting ideas of health communication and spreading awareness on various health services. The main element of social marketing is formulation of a number of programmes which target a selected audience for whom these ideas hold relevance. Thus, social marketing is a strategy that involves disseminating a specific idea or a set of ideas for a set of audiences.

Though the communication of the message is the central point of social marketing approach, a number of marketing strategies are also used in this arena. It may be noted that the concepts of market segmentation, idea configuration, communication, facilitation, incentives, consumer research and exchange theories to maximize target group response are considered important in social marketing approach.

In 1950s, public health campaigns made an effective use of social marketing leading to the success of these campaigns. Kiran Prasad has referred to many such campaigns of public health conducted in developing countries. These campaigns included family planning, immunisation campaigns and oral dehydration. In the recent years, many developing countries have made use of social marketing in campaigns against tobacco usage, for condom use and other similar behaviours.

In 2020, health ministries of the Government of India and state government devised and successfully used social marketing strategies for spreading messages on COVID- 19 pandemic. Other medical and health organisations like Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR), private hospitals and NGOs adopted social

marketing tools for creating awareness among the people regarding identification, prevention and cure of the pandemic.

Check Your Progress 4

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. Explain the points you will keep in mind while designing social marketing campaigns for Development.

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15.6 DEVELOPMENT SUPPORT COMMUNICATION

The main difference between development communication and development support communication is the method in which the information or knowledge is spread among people. According to Melkote and H Leslie, development support communication revolves around pluralistic and participatory approaches.

It may be noted that the top down perspective of transmission models has been rejected by the proponents of development support communication. When we talk about development support communication, the central idea is that of empowerment of the people. Melkote and Steevs are of the opinion that inequalities in the distribution of power and resources are a major impediment to development. According to them, no development is possible without addressing the issue of inequalities.

In developing societies like India, the government is expected to formulate development policies which are inclusive in nature and target the social and economic well-being of the deprived, impoverished and discarded sections of the society. The objective of development support communication is equitable distribution of resources and empowerment of marginalised sections. Development support communication helps in the creation of a pluralistic society. People in such a society should have the willingness to acknowledge and participate in the development process.

Check Your Progress 5

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. Highlight the key points of difference between Development Communication and Development Support Communication.

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15.7 LET US SUM UP

The concept of development communication has gone through sea change over the years due to technological innovations, economic advancement and geo-political realignments. Scholars have experimented and evolved various models and approaches of development communication. In this unit, we have discussed and understood the paradigm shift in the concept of development communication.

This unit has helped us in understanding the importance of communication and participation in the process of development. Policy formulations by the government, interventions and campaigns for policy change, advocacy for pushing the development agenda, the importance of technology in policy monitoring and advocacy and the issues of accountability have been discussed in detail.

In 21st century, development demands promotion and publicity of development oriented programmes and policies. The objective is to reach out to beneficiaries and seek their participation to ensure the success of the development scheme. So, the parameters of marketing have been applied in development as well. Internet has helped in building the social marketing approach. All this has been discussed in this unit.

While talking about major trends in development communication, this unit also explains the concept of development support communication. The unit also underlines the difference between development communication and development Support Communication.

15.10 KEYWORDS

- **Development Support Communication:** Development Support Communication is specifically designed to undertake communication activities oriented towards participation of the people for achieving specific goals of a development programme.
- **Participatory Communication:** Participatory Communication aims at actively involving people and making them instrumental for their own sake in socio-economic development process.
- **Communication:** Communication is the act of conveying or disseminating messages and meanings from one entity or group to another entity or group through the use of mutually understood verbal and non-verbal language.
- **Development:** Development is a process that brings a positive change in the life of the people. Development symbolises growth and progress comprising social, economic, environmental and demographic components. The purpose of development is to raise the living standards and the quality of life of the people.
- **ICT:** Information and communications technology is an extensional term for information technology that emphasises on the role of unified communication in the field of education and development.

15.9 REFERENCES AND FURTHER READINGS

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15.10 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress: 1

1. Explain the Consciousness Model.
 - Consciousness Model was proposed by Paolo Freire in 1973.
 - He believed communication is an element inseparable from social and political processes of development and only individuals with independent and critical conscience are capable of influencing and bringing about a change in the society.
 - Freire contested the theory that only disseminating information or transferring knowledge to a passive receiver could bring about a change.
 - He argued that development communication would be effective only when it looks beyond providing technical knowledge and skills and focuses more on raising awareness and approaching the developmental issues at the root.
 - He argued that development communication would be effective only when it looks beyond providing technical knowledge and skills and focuses more on raising awareness and approaching the developmental issues at the root.
2. Discuss with example the Social Marketing approach to development.
 - Social Marketing approach to development is an approach used to change, maintain or inform people in a directional way leading to development. There is extensive use of internet for information dissemination and various social media platforms are used for this purpose.
 - Communication under this approach usually takes place through Transmedia storytelling which helps in catching the public eye and attention.
 - Every day, numerous projects are emerging which are using modern technology to circulate information using mobilise resources and leading to collective action.
 - For example, it was seen that in the movement against AIDS, apart from the creation of small groups and communities, the mass media was also used extensively.

3. “There is no development without communication” explain in terms of Communication and Participation.
- Participatory communication plays a crucial role in promoting development. A popular FAO (Food and Agriculture Organisation of the United States) slogan says, “There is no development without communication” (Balit, 1988).
 - The key stakeholders of participatory development communication are the people at grassroots. This model aims to establish a dialogue so that both initiatives and feedbacks received can be applied to unidirectional goal of development.
 - Participation ensures dynamism in guiding the process of development so that the audience, instead of just being passive receivers, become the active driving force.

Check Your Progress: 2

1. In brief explain the Participatory Communication Approach.
- This perspective works on the premise that people who are considered to be the recipients of development cannot just be passive audiences, instead they have to be the active participants in the process of development.
 - Participation Communication Approach is a system that aims to correct the different theories and models of development process by insisting on the concept of empowerment.
 - The main aim of this approach is to use different forms of media such as traditional, inter-personal and social means of communication that strengthens and provides communities with an opportunity to visualize directions and solution to their issues.
2. People are the center in the process of communication. Comment.
- In participatory communication model, horizontal flow of communication and dialogue has a vital role, and so the relation among empowerment, communication and participation becomes quite important.
 - The exchange of knowledge among people and their participation in the process of communication are considered essential for development.
 - The role of people in the empowering process is also an essential factor in determining the direction of development.

Check Your Progress: 3

1. What are some commonly used advocacy techniques?

Some of the commonly used advocacy techniques, include

- Conduct of organised campaigns for policy change
- Measures of critical engagement such as policy monitoring and policy dialogue

- Launch and demonstration of projects which can inform and influence future policy making
2. What is the importance of policy monitoring?
- Policy monitoring ensures accountability of the government particularly in a democratic setup.
 - Public institutions can perform this job effectively by exerting pressure on elected governments.
 - Policy monitoring by advocacy groups and other public interest institutions leads to transparency since reports published by such groups bring forward the truth and the loopholes of administration. This creates a pressure on the government for better implementation and action.
 - Policy monitoring activities can be used to collect and analyze data related to development and implementation on specific development programmes and policies. It can also help link policies to specific outcomes and help identify and evaluate policy impacts.
 - Policy monitoring allows policymakers and interested actors to systematically examine the process of creating a policy, implementing it, and evaluating its effects

Check Your Progress: 4

1. Explain the points you will keep in mind while designing social marketing campaigns for Development.
- Set a target audience
 - Set Campaign aims and goals
 - Choose a portal and social media channel
 - Plan the message
 - Keep taking responses to boost productivity
 - Carry out analysis of the responses and adapt to changes.
 - State an Example

Check Your Progress: 5

1. Highlight the key points of differences between Development Communication and Development Support Communication.
- Development communication comprises messages to people for betterment of their economic and social conditions whereas Development Support Communication addresses development planning and the plan of operation for implementation
 - Development Communication focuses on directional messages and information dissemination whereas Melkote and H Leslie Steeves elaborate development support communication revolves around pluralistic and participatory approaches.

UNIT 16 SOCIAL AND BEHAVIOUR CHANGE COMMUNICATION

Structure

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16.0 INTRODUCTION

You have read in the previous units that for things to improve they require change at various levels and in different forms. The idea of communication for social change is to make use of all available information structures to bring changes for improvement in people's lives. Recognising the dynamic interaction between the socio-cultural environment, social norms and individual behaviours have brought about the shifts from information – education communication to communications that will lead to behaviour change.

Mefalopulos (2008) notes two modes of communication approaches in the evolution of social and behaviour change communication. The dominant paradigm based top-down approaches, or the *monologic* mode of communication verses the *dialogic* mode, based on the two-way model. As a result, the field of communications for social change has expanded to include a range of approaches for accomplishing different programme goals and outcomes. While mass media remains key to raising awareness and informing the masses, interpersonal

approaches are crucial for grass-root and policy advocacy initiatives and locally generated community media for facilitating participatory communications.

In this unit, we shall discuss the concept and principles of social and behaviour change communication (SBCC) and trace the shift of IEC and BCC to SBCC. We shall take an overview of various strategic approaches to SBCC and delineate the steps to design a SBCC strategy.

16.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After going through this unit, you should be able to:

- discuss the concept and role of SBCC;
- describe shifts from IEC, BCC to SBCC;
- discuss various strategic approaches to SBCC;
- define the concept of social and behaviour change communication; and
- design a social and behaviour change communication strategy.

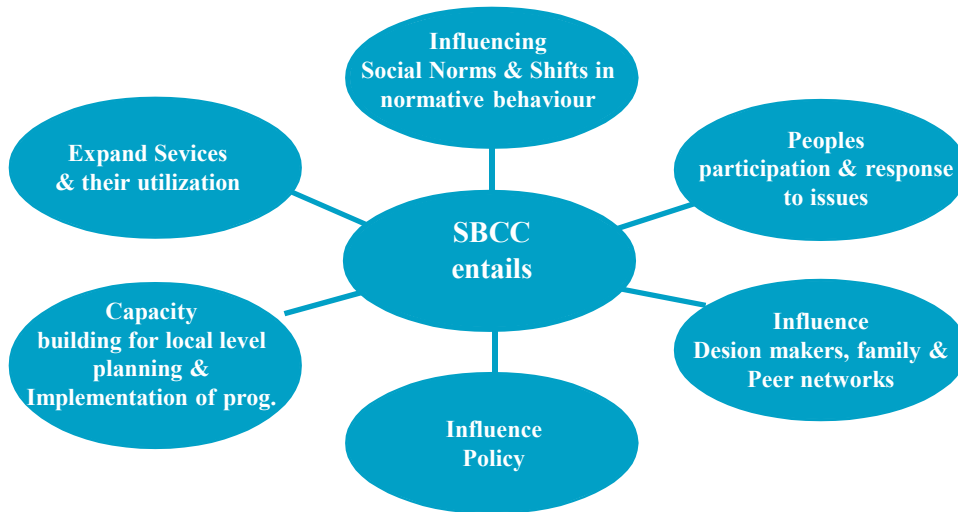
16.2 SOCIAL AND BEHAVIOUR CHANGE COMMUNICATION: CONCEPT AND ROLE

The field of communication for social change has seen strategic shifts. From designing communication media for delivering messages for promoting desired behaviours to include the full range of ways in which people individually and collectively convey meaning.

Social and behaviour change has evolved as a systematic research-based consultative process for addressing knowledge, attitudes and practices. Enabling different stakeholders and community groups to engage in participatory processes to define their needs and demand their rights. The collaborative, transformative actions emphasise public and private dialogue to change behaviour on a large scale, including norms and structural inequalities.

Addressing individual behaviours, which are shaped by social, cultural, economic and political contexts, requires interactive approaches and a mix of communication channels in order to encourage and sustain positive and appropriate behaviours. SBCC programmes employ a range of approaches, with well-defined strategies and participatory practices. Social and behaviour change communication provides individuals with relevant information and motivation.

Social and behaviour change hence is a deliberate and iterative process of public and private dialogue, debate, and negotiation that focuses on the community as the unit of change. It aims to change behaviours on a large scale, eliminate harmful social and cultural practices, and change social norms and structural inequalities. The participatory process allows communities to define their needs, identify their rights, and collaboratively transform the way their social system is organised, including distribution of power within social and political institutions. Collective community action, based on negotiating and partnership, creates joint ownership of the change process. Community members control the tools of communication, which fosters empowerment and helps them shift social norms, policies, and culture.



16.2.1 IEC, BCC, SBCC: The Shift

The terms Information Education Communication (IEC), Behaviour Change Communication (BCC) and SBCC are generally used inter-changeably. However, these terms are different as “Information, education and communication (IEC)” comprise of activities when communication media like posters, leaflets, radio broadcasts, etc. are used for providing people with information for awareness building and ‘tell them’ how to behave. It was realised that providing information alone is not enough for making personal choices and bringing about behaviour change among individuals. Communication strategies can have positive and sustainable effect when designed using a structured communication plan i.e. communications are designed for specific target audience after a situation analysis; pretesting of material; clear objectives, indicators and targets; a distribution plan with follow-up; regular feedback through monitoring; and formal evaluation.

This approach is called Behaviour Change Communication (BCC), and employs a more participatory methodology, and focuses more on the end actions of the client. BCC hence is said to be “an interactive process with communities to develop tailored messages and approaches using variety of communication channels to develop positive behaviours; promote and sustain individual, community and societal behaviour change; and maintain appropriate behaviours”. BCC performs following tasks:

- Develops *communication strategies* to promote *positive behaviours* that are appropriate to their settings

Provides a *supportive environment* that enables people to initiate and *sustain* positive behaviours

BCC thus builds on IEC approach, however, it focuses on promoting individual behaviour change and does not account for interplay of biology with social determinants (social norms and cultural practices) that shape human interaction.

In order to influence social dimensions of health and wellbeing, practitioners formulated a strategic, systematic and targeted communication approach and coined the term Social and Behaviour Change Communication (SBCC).

SBCC goes beyond the delivery of message to encompasses the full range of ways in which people individually and collectively convey meaning. It is the systematic application of interactive, theory-based, and research-driven communication processes and strategies to address tipping points for change at individual, community, and social levels. Among the powerful tools employed by SBCC programmes are mass media, community-level activities, IPC, information and communication technologies and new media. SBCC is “use of communication to change behaviours, including service utilisation, by positively influencing knowledge, attitude, and social norms” (Johns Hopkins University). It aims to change both social conditions and individual behaviours. It applies a comprehensive, socio-ecological model to identify tipping points for change by examining individual knowledge, motivation, and other behaviour change communication concepts. It also maps the social, cultural, and gender norms, skills, physical and economic access, and legislation that contribute to an enabling environment.

SBCC is amalgamation of all approaches of development communication discussed earlier. Primarily it uses key strategies of *social mobilisation*, as it encourages wider participation, coalition building, and ownership, including community mobilisation; and *behaviour change communication*, as it changes in knowledge, attitudes, and practices among specific audiences.

Hence, SBCC ensures sustained demand and access to services by engaging community leaders and influencers and advocating shifting underlying norms that affect service-seeking behaviours.

The addition of “S” to “BCC” signifies that individuals and their immediate social relationships are dependent on the larger structural and environmental systems. Gender norms, power hierarchies (class and caste), cultural practices, societal, organisational, political atmosphere and local economy have a profound effect on an individual’s compliance with healthy practices. Consequently, SBCC encompasses three core elements:

- *Communication* uses channels and themes accessible and acceptable to an intended audience based on their needs and preferences;
- *Behaviour change* makes efforts to simplify specific health actions, make them feasible so as to protect or improve health outcomes; and
- *Social change* brings about shifts in operationalisation of an issue, community mobilisation, public policies, and gender norms and relations.

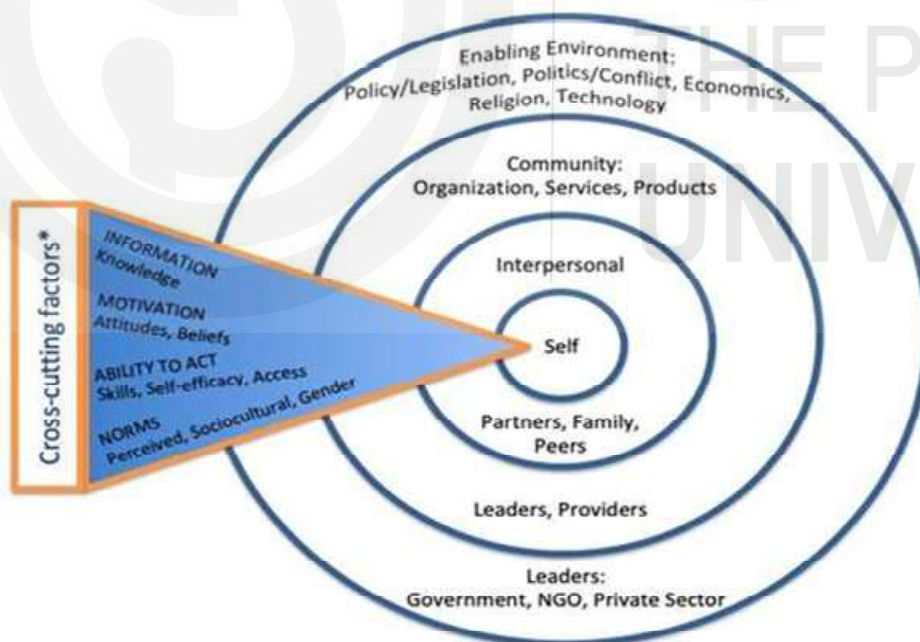
SBCC is a transformative process of social engagement, reflection, and practice that works on various dimensions: an individual’s behaviour and practices, collective action by networks, social and cultural structures, and an enabling environment.

16.2.2 Principles of SBCC

Social and behaviour change communication relies on certain principles, which are also central aspects of its strategy. These are embedded in the design to ensure effective delivery of message ensuing positive, sustained behaviours.

- 1) **SBCC is a process** - not a product. Communication products such as posters, television or radio spots, flipcharts or leaflets constitute only one component of the process.

- 2) **SBCC is research-driven** - Effective SBCC starts with research and analysis to understand intended audience and their context. Consequently, strategies are developed to ensure that key messages across multiple channels are consistent.
- 3) **SBCC is strategic** - SBCC programmes are grounded in theory (discussed in the next section) and use evidence that helps programmes understand the situation, the audience, and existing programmes.
- 4) **SBCC caters to multiple stakeholders** - Individual and social change depends on larger structural systems and norms. Hence, achieving sustainable social and behaviour change requires SBCC programmes to work at multiple levels of the system – individual, family, community, and political environment. SBCC hence operates through the socio ecological model that provides insights on multiple levels of the causes of problems and recognises the interplay of personal and environmental factors upon each other.
- 5) **SBCC uses multiple media channels** - SBCC coordinates messages across a variety of communication channels (print, community-level, social media, IPC, radio, TV) to reach multiple levels of society. Behaviour and social change is more likely through repeated exposure to messages.
- 6) **SBCC is informed by monitoring and evaluation** – Monitoring & Evaluation (M&E) activities are operationalised during design stage. An effective SBCC programme uses M&E to enhance its implementation and evolve its later phases.



Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

- 1) What are the major differences between IEC, BCC and SBCC?

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- 2) What are the key strategies of SBCC?

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16.3 STRATEGIC APPROACHES TO SBCC

Various strategies are followed for SBCC which differ in their approaches - while some have a ‘communicator centric’ orientation emanating largely from the dominant paradigm. Others have more ‘receiver centric’ approaches aimed at strengthening dialogue with stake holders; enhance local level participation and ownership of programmes for sustainable impact. Depending on the objectives and expected outcomes most development communication initiatives use a combination of approaches. In this section, we shall discuss some such strategies.

16.3.1 Social Marketing

Social marketing (SM) involves use of commercial marketing techniques to promote pro-social behaviour. Using theories from the marketing and advertising disciplines, it applies consumer behaviour theories for development communication. According to Kotler and Zaltman (1971), Social marketing is “the design, implementation, and control of programmes to influence the acceptability of social ideas and involving consideration of product planning, pricing, communication, distribution, and marketing research”. In contrast to commercial marketing, which is not concerned with the social consequences of its actions, and cause related marketing that use social issues to market products, social marketing campaigns are designed to promote socially beneficial practices or products in a target group. By positioning social ideas within the context of community beliefs, SM provides information to help bridge the gap between products and consumers’ unfulfilled demands. Social marketing approach has been used by the government for issues like family planning, smoking, alcoholism, AIDS etc. where TV and print ads as well as direct campaigns with local NGOs have been used to target different groups.

16.3.2 Health Promotion and Health Education

In developing nations, campaigns promoting maternal and child health, immunisation and family planning, and preventing diseases such as HIV rely on

health education as a fundamental tool. In 1970s, many health education programmes emerged in the developed world for addressing lifestyle related health problems like smoking, obesity etc. whose approach was also used for addressing third world problems of child survival among others. These programmes had a very individualistic orientation focusing on individual behaviours and ignored the socio-cultural factors responsible for diseases and peoples health behaviours. It was during the 1980s that more sophisticated, theory-informed interventions, accounting for social and economic context of behavioural decisions were developed. Hence, health education was strengthened and integrated individual and social actions of people to help them make healthy choices. These programmes began to enhance personal and social skills of the target audience in order to influence their health behaviour choices. Several theories of behaviour change were developed by scholars (Bandura, Ajzen, Fishbein, Rogers) to explain the complex relationships between knowledge, beliefs and social norms. These theories also guided content of educational programmes and promoted behaviour change in a given context.

16.3.3 Entertainment Education

Entertainment-education (EE) is a communication strategy concerned with behaviour change by dissemination of information through the media. Based on Bandura's (1977) Social Learning Theory, EE is centered on the idea that individuals learn behaviours by observing role models, particularly in the mass media. Another underpin of EE strategies is the concept that expected changes result from self-efficacy and the belief of individuals that they can complete specific tasks (Bandura 1994, Maibach and Murphy 1995). EE thus involves the purposive design of media messages to both entertain and educate, with the view to increasing audience knowledge about a social issue, shift attitudes, and change overt behaviour (Singhal and Rogers, 1999). Systematic research in the design and implementation of social messages helps design effective EE strategies. Focusing on both individual and community level change EE uses a range of widely popular entertainment media like TV soap operas, Radio dramas, songs, theatre, comics etc. for resulting in pro-social behaviour. A Peruvian telenovela, *Simplemente María*, pioneered the entertainment-education approach in 1969; it has subsequently been used as a development communication tool in several countries. EE strategy has been used in India recently as part of popular serials like *Kyun Ki Jeena Isi Ka Naam Hai* and *Balika Vadhu*.

16.3.4 Advocacy

Advocacy communications involves certain specific processes designed to influence decision makers, stakeholders and relevant audiences to garner support and implement actions for seeking change regarding specific issues. It is a means of seeking change in governance, power relations, social relations, attitudes and even institutional functioning. As part of the Communication for Development (C4D) strategy, ongoing advocacy processes, policy makers, political and social leaders at all levels are influenced to create and sustain enabling policy and legislative environments and to allocate resources equitably (UNDP, 2011).

The aim of advocacy is to influence

- The political climate
- Modify/change existing laws or policies, promote new policies

- Redefine public perceptions of social norms
- Community support and empowerment
- Funding and resource allocation decisions

For example, organisations advocate for reserving greater women's representation in the Indian legislature.

16.3.5 Social Mobilisation

Community participation is a collective participatory process that empowers groups and their communities to reflect on and address a range of behaviours, issues and decisions that affect their lives. Community participation raises awareness, strengthens capacities and leads to proactive involvement of people in their development. Social mobilisation engages a range of stakeholders around a common issue. It is a wider process of garnering support from selected partners to raise demand for services or products, or sustain progress toward a development objective. Social mobilisation reaches out to different groups such as leaders (community, political, opinion), educational institutions, civil society organisations, professional groups/networks, farmers' cooperatives, micro-credit groups/self-help groups, youth groups, women's groups, community-based organisations, faith-based organisations, professional networks and the private sector and catalyse them to take action and/or support change about a common cause.

Using a combination of alliance-building and partnerships along with media campaigns, social mobilisation motivates various partners at national and local levels to raise awareness and demand for a particular development objective and to provide sustainable, multi-faceted solutions to broad social problems. Building partnerships is key to community mobilisation as sustainable outcomes require collaboration at multiple levels, and partnerships yield stronger impacts than isolated efforts.

16.3.6 Institutional Capacity Building

Development agencies perceive Institutional Capacity Building (ICB) as possibly the most important way to achieve superordinate goals of development. Capacity building of any institution simply means improving performance of development professionals, and increasing their capacities in order to develop new capabilities, to learn from and adapt to their environments, to partake in activities of programmes of change. This is to ensure effective development delivery. According to the World Bank, ICB encompasses three major activities:

1. Skill upgrading
2. Procedural improvements
3. Organisational strengthening

ICB occurs by acquiring resources (human, financial, networks, knowledge, systems and culture) and integrating them in a way that leads to change in individual behaviour and ultimately to more efficient and effective operations of institutions and organisations. For this, mechanisms such as legal, judicial and electoral systems, regulating the societies and economies are strengthened.

This approach emphasises that strengthening communication capacities, including professional and institutional infrastructure, is necessary to enable: (i) a free, independent and pluralist media that serves public interest; (ii) broad public access to variety of communication channels, including community media; (iii) a non-discriminating regulatory environment; (iv) media accountability systems; and (v) freedom of expression, all groups enjoy the right to voice opinions, and participate in development debates and decision making. Influx of newer technologies in 1990s made communication environment more conducive by enabling global reach at low cost; ordinary individuals broadcast information (bottom-up message initiation) and co-creation of messages e.g. Integrated Voice Response systems for agricultural services; providing opportunities for convenient information seeking through vast array of sources, which are on-demand; among others. Designing communication strategies integrated with technological amplifiers have relatively simplified diffusion of ideas, products and services into the contemporary world.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What is the importance of social mobilisation?

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2. What are the three major activities for capacity building of institutions?

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16.4 DESIGNING A SBCC STRATEGY

Communication strategy is the bridge between situation analysis and the actual implementation of a SBCC programme, including the creation and rollout of materials, products, and activities. It guides the rest of the intervention by providing direction and ensuring that different products, materials, and activities all ultimately work well together and support each other toward a clear vision of change. It ensures that the plan is implemented according to the diagnosis and decisions. Simply put, development of a communication strategy ought to be guided by evidence-based insights. There are various models that can be used

for strategy development, these include for example, ACADA, COMBI, the Health Communication Programme Cycle, the SCALE process, C-Change and the P-Process. These models provide a stepwise guide to how behaviour change is expected to happen and help formulate a strategic programme that is grounded in theory and has measurable impact. Different organisations have their own terminology of such processes; essentially, they follow the same course. In a nutshell, the five steps are: inquire, design the strategy, create and test, mobilise and monitor, and evaluate and evolve.

Following are three over-arching aspects that are embedded in most models and SBCC approaches work best when all three guide the process.

Participation: Each step should be informed by a robust group of partners, decision-makers, target audience, and subject experts. It is critical to have representation from all stakeholder groups during implementation; this spreads project ownership and is the first step to on the road to sustainability.

Capacity building: It uses a blended learning approach to capacity strengthening at the individual, organisational and system levels, including a mix of on-job coaching and mentoring and formal training opportunities to ensure that learning happens at all levels.

SBCC Theory: Behavioural change theories are attempts to explain why behaviours change. These theories cite environmental, personal, and behavioural characteristics as the major factors in behavioural determination. The key is to identify a theory that matches how one comprehends about what influences promoted behaviour. *Socio-ecological model (SEM)* is a theory-based framework for understanding the multifaceted effects of personal and environmental factors that determine behaviours. It also identifies behavioural and organisational leverage points, and intermediaries for behaviour promotion. The most effective approach to behaviour change uses a mix of interventions at all levels of this model.

Categorised according to socio-ecological level, following are some widely used behaviour change models and theories:

Individual Level

- **Health Belief Model:** It focuses on an individual's perception of threat and susceptibility to a health problem, and the efficiency of promoted health behaviour in preventing or managing it.
- **Theory of planned behaviour:** It states that an individual is more likely to perform a behaviour if behavioural intention is realised.
- **Stages of change (Trans-theoretical model):** An individual passes through a series of stages as they move from a state of unawareness to awareness about a health problem, thereby influencing their readiness to change towards healthy behaviours.

Interpersonal Level

- **Social learning theory:** Behaviour is based on a dynamic reciprocal theory according to which personal factors, environmental influences and behaviour interact continually.

- **Diffusion of innovations:** It explains how new ideas, products, services and social practices spread within a society.

These models illustrate how change is facilitated in an individual and within a community. Identifying a suitable theory on the basis of promoted behaviour, programme planners then design a *theory of change*, a method that explains how a given intervention, or set of interventions, are expected to lead to a specific development change. Drawing on a causal analysis based on available evidence the change theories are applied during the planning phase.

16.4.1 Analyse the Situation

The first step is situation analysis which helps to understand the problem to be addressed, identify groups affected by the problem, individual behaviours associated with the problem, map factors that facilitate change in behaviours, enlist potential stakeholders, and determine a vision of what should happen. In case of insufficient or outdated data, conducting a formative research fills the gaps in knowledge of programme planners. Quantitative tools such as survey data and qualitative tools such as focus group discussions, observation checklist and key informant interviews are recommended.

Numerous tasks need to be undertaken in order to assess the situation, audience, and environment. These tasks enable a clear understanding of the challenge to be addressed.

Clarify shared vision: A vision clearly states ‘where we want to be’. It is shared by all stakeholders (household, government, community), and must secure a strong commitment to overcome obstacles. For example, Urban Health Initiative (UHI) vision statement is “Every household in Uttar Pradesh will have confident, expert couples who discuss, choose, and consistently use the modern contraceptive method best suited to their needs in order to realise their dreams and achieve their aspirations of a bright future for their families.”

Identify challenges and root causes: It is of core importance to cull out the root (or primary) cause to determine the main reason for the situation. Challenges usually have underlying causes and thus, many plausible solutions. For example, population control is a problem that can be addressed by strengthening family planning commodities through a service delivery (social marketing) or eliminating misconceptions on family planning methods bringing shifts in attitudes. Problem tree, fishbone diagram and force-field analysis are widely used tools.

Understand context of core challenge: Examining the interconnected influences of family, peers, community and society on individual behaviour helps gathering information needed for situation analysis. In Social Ecological Model, individuals’ decision-making and subsequent behaviours depend not only on their own characteristics, but also social and environmental contexts in which they live.

Summarise core challenge: Core challenge statement describes the key behaviours, norms or policy needed to make the shared vision a reality. It explains why there is a difference between the vision and current situation. It may also include consequences, if challenge is not addressed.

Determine programme theory: SBCC programmes are more effective if they are based on social and behaviour science theories (BCC theories listed earlier). Audience's behaviours vary; some behaviours are driven by individual preferences, needs or desires while others by social pressures. For example, deciding to brush one's teeth before bed is based on an individual need of maintaining dental hygiene. On the other hand Structural or contextual conditions such as access to resources, with availability can also drive behaviours such as purchase of insecticide treated bed nets.

Identify potential priority groups: Demographic variables such as age, sex, education, locale, occupation, parity, media exposure and economic status that differentiate the affected groups from those who are not at risk or are unaffected by the challenge define the target audience in a programme. Applying a gender lens i.e. understanding gender roles and relationships related to the challenge, identifying differences in social norms and expectations from females and males, their knowledge and attitude levels, how females and males are affected by the challenge, and whether gender inequity worsens the situation.

Assess communication needs and resources: This includes assessing potential communication resources that may help carry out SBCC interventions, identifying current communication activities being implemented to address the challenge, and determining communication capacity building needs for IPC, local media, digital and social media, and community communication partners. If communication efforts advocate for uptake of services or products, then link between demand and supply must be strengthened.

Conduct participation analysis: This task requires gathering information on partners and collaborators, their expertise, and determines if there are capacity building requirements.

16.4.2 Know the Audience

A SBCC programme caters to enhance wellbeing of *primary audience* i.e. directly affected by or is at most risk due to the challenge or those who make decision on behalf of those affected (caregivers of young children). *Influencing audience* i.e. family members, service providers, community leaders and teachers influence primary audience's way of thinking, either directly or indirectly.

This step requires three tasks to be fulfilled. First, segmenting the potential priority groups identified in step 1 determines specific audiences to focus. This enables implementation of activities, which are effective and appropriate for each of the specific audiences, by developing customised messages and material suited to various groups. Audience are usually segmented on the basis of demography, geography, socio-cultural context, behaviours, psychographic characteristics (personality, interests, lifestyle) and ideational factors that promote or hinder social and behaviour change.

Second, facilitated discussions help in prioritising audience segments i.e. ranking of potential segments based on proportion of population in intended target group, programme objectives, vulnerability, their likeliness to change and availability of resources. Finally, a personalised audience profile aids in bringing audience to life as it embodies their characteristics. This profile includes current behaviours, motivations, emotions, values and attitudes as well as socio-demographic

information. By focusing on an individual with defined characteristics, instead of a collection of statistics or a mass of anonymous people, helps in development of appropriate communication messages.

16.4.3 Identify Communication Objectives

The third step is to identify communication objectives to reflect the needs of the intended audience and the goals set by the programme. These objectives tackle the core challenge. They clearly state the desired change in behaviour, social norms and policies; intended effect of change; and time required for change to happen.

SMART (Specific, Measurable, Appropriate, Realistic, Time bound) approach is key to formulating strategic communication objectives. It is noteworthy that each of the primary and influencing audiences require their own sets of communication objectives, but it is important to maintain consistency in the types of changes that are expected from both audiences. To estimate how much change is manageable, one may consider the overall context of problem that varies from 'barriers to change' to 'incentives not to change'; examine research data and reports describing past experiences of similar communication programmes; and check availability of resources. In addition, existing baseline measures needs to be included in the objectives to propose realistic and measurable amount of change. Furthermore, determining the time frame in which change will be achieved is crucial; it ensure adequate time for change to effectively happen.

16.4.4 Strategic Approaches

As discussed in section 7.3 of this unit, several approaches are required to address multiple audiences across social ecological levels. The commonly used approaches are entertainment-education, advocacy, community media, community and social mobilisation, distance learning, peer communication (IPC), mass media and information and communication technologies. It is convenient to incorporate these approaches into a goal-oriented campaign as a campaign uses a blend of approaches (usually mass media in addition to on-ground, community-based interventions) to benefit an individual and/or society within a stipulated time period. This helps in not only ensuring consistency and coordination among partners but also create synergistic programme interventions.

The strategic approaches describe how the communication objectives will be achieved; they guide development and implementation of programme activities and help determine the vehicles, tools and media to be used. These approaches convey and reinforce the messages. Hence, understanding the complexity and sensitivity of challenge is crucial to this process. In addition, following are to be considered while identifying such strategic approaches:

Effectiveness of approach to address challenge: Analysis of health interventions show that social norms (such as child marriage) are more successfully dealt with entertainment education while IPC is more effective in addressing tabooed subjects (such as HIV/other sexually transmitted diseases).

Method	How Method Helps Change Behaviour
Posters, Counseling cards, Brochures	Provide Information
Radio, TV, Songs	Remind people about malaria action
Stories, Drama, Plays	Present role models for behaviour change
Discussions	Provide opportunities to plan for problem solving
Peer groups	Provide encouragement

- **Literacy:** Understanding the educational background of audience is essential as interventions that rely on the written word do not benefit if a large proportion of target audience is illiterate.
- **Desired reach:** Mass media, internet-based and Health interventions can provide regional and national reach.
- **Cost:** Cost effectiveness of all potential approaches must be considered in accordance with the budgetary allowances.
- **Innovation:** A new and unexpected approach can make it more appealing and develop interest in audience.
- **Age group:** Mobile based and social media approaches can engage the young adults more.

16.4.5 Positioning and Strategy Outline

The next step is positioning which aims to determine an identity or a central theme of a SBCC programme that shapes the development of messages. Deciding on the tone and appeal is key to setting the identity of any SBCC programme. Positioning presents the strategic approaches in a way that is persuasive and appealing to the intended audience. It also helps in creative implementation i.e. guides the creative process by ensuring a consistent voice across all messages, and checking whether programme activities correspond with, and reinforce each other for a cumulative effect. An effective position:

- Resonates with the audience
- Differentiates from the competition
- Stands out as better than the known alternatives
- Provides a benefit that is worth the cost or effort.

16.4.6 Implementation Plan

Details of the *who*, *what*, *when* and *how* constitute the implementation plan that covers partner roles, operational activities, proposed timeline, budgetary and management considerations. First, success of any communication effort relies on the combined expertise of participating agencies. These areas may include creative design, advocacy, service delivery, media placement, training, community mobilisation, monitoring and evaluation. In addition, involving the audience in design and implementation is crucial.

Second, a detailed plan of activities (on-ground) is developed. It is important to include intermediary steps, and determine the sequence of activities. Third, a timeline is established, periodically reviewed and modified as changes occur.

Finally, budget for SBCC interventions includes description of employees' salaries, resources for training, fieldwork, accommodation and travel allowances, other mobilisation and outreach activities, production of communication material, data processing and analysis, report writing, dissemination of findings, and other communication, administrative and overhead costs. It is recommended to allocate 10% budget to monitoring and evaluation.

16.4.7 Monitoring and Evaluation

The final step is Monitoring and Evaluation (M&E). Ideally, effects of all SBCC programmes are compared with its objectives, and contributing factors and/or constraints to achievement of programme goals are identified. Results from such efforts advance theory development and understanding. M&E team is involved at the planning stage; it is responsible for identifying valid, reliable, specific, sensitive and measurable indicators to track progress of programme; it helps in mapping impact of SBCC efforts later.

Monitoring checks whether the programme is on-track i.e. it focuses on WHAT is happening (are frontline workers using communication skills? Are adolescents talking to their parents about education and delaying marriage?). Evaluation, on the other hand, is a more comprehensive study of communication's role in the overall programme, and is done, usually, at the end of the programme cycle. It determines the effect of programme and prepares for the next implementation phase. By being more comprehensive, evaluation explores WHY behaviours are happening or not. Monitoring becomes too heavy if it addresses these issues. An effective monitoring and evaluation plan suggests changes in implementation plan or indicators, and ways to address the issues arisen.

More and more development programmes are adopting "participatory monitoring and evaluation". This approach involves the people addressed by the programme in monitoring and evaluating its activities. These people track programme progress, and reflect upon and learn from their own experiences. By the virtue of participatory M&E, participants' motivation and sense of ownership is substantially improved, and project is more likely to have sustainable outcomes. Essentially, participatory M&E is integrating community participation with M&E process.

Activity-1

Choose any government programme implemented within the last 5 years. Identify the key SBCC strategies used, target audience catered and the problems addressed.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What is SMART Indicator? How it is related to SMART objectives?

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2. Why are SBCC programmes increasingly using participatory M&E?

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16.5 LET US SUM UP

In this unit we discussed that Social and Behaviour Change Communication (SBCC) has been in existence for quite a long time, but has had different terminologies. We further discussed how dialogic processes are integral to this approach, and involving all stakeholders during design is crucial for sustainable solutions. Different approaches and components such as social mobilisation, behaviour change, communication, institution building and health promotion intertwine to formulate an effective SBCC effort.

Just like a sales venture is in vain if the consumers' needs are not fulfilled, the idea of SBCC is incomplete without the people, particularly the 'last' section of the society. It accommodates the contextual needs of people in the design process, thus SBCC is more inclusive.

16.6 REFERENCES AND FURTHER READINGS

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Servaes, J. (Ed.). (2007), Communication for development and social change, Sage Publications, India.

16.7 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. IEC comprises of activities when communication media like posters, leaflets, radio broadcasts, etc. are used for providing people with information on how to behave. On the other hand, BCC develops communication strategies to promote positive behaviours by building conducive environment that enables people to initiate and sustain positive behaviours. However, SBCC takes the process of BCC one step further in order to influence social dimensions of health and wellbeing. It is a strategic, systematic and targeted communication approach that improves health behaviours throughout the continuum of care.
2. SBCC uses social mobilisation, as it encourages wider participation, coalition building, and ownership, including community mobilisation; and behaviour change communication, as it changes in knowledge, attitudes, and practices among specific audiences. Hence, SBCC ensures sustained demand and

access to services by engaging community leaders and influencers and advocating shifting underlying norms that affect service-seeking behaviours.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) C4D programmes need support from selected partners to raise demand for services or products, or sustain progress toward a development objective. Social Mobilisation uses alliance building along with media campaigns, and motivates various partners at national and local levels to raise awareness and demand, thereby providing sustainable, multi-faceted solutions to social problems.
- 2) Three major activities for capacity building of institutions are: skill upgrading, procedural improvements and organisational strengthening. ICB occurs by acquiring resources (human, financial, networks, knowledge, systems and culture) and integrating them in a way that changes individual behaviour and enables effective operations of institutions.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) SMART indicators are specific, measurable, appropriate, realistic and time-bound. The indicators measure change in programme variables before and after the implementation, hence appropriate indicators must be set before identifying SMART objectives. Existing baseline measures inform the communication strategies, which are based on programme objectives.
- 2) Development programme planners are adopting participatory M&E strategy as it engages the people whose problems are to be addressed. Consequently, these people track programme progress, and reflect upon and learn from their own experiences. PM&E enhances participants' motivation and sense of ownership, which drives the project towards sustainable outcomes.

UNIT 17 SOCIAL AND BEHAVIOUR CHANGE COMMUNICATION (SBCC): CASE - STUDIES

Structure

- 17.0 Introduction
- 17.1 Learning Outcomes
- 17.2 Environment
- 17.3 Agriculture
- 17.4 Population
- 17.5 Education
- 17.6 Health
- 17.7 Gender issues
- 17.8 Governance
- 17.9 Let Us Sum Up
- 17.10 References and Further Readings
- 17.11 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

17.0 INTRODUCTION

In the previous Unit, you have read that Development Support Communication (DSC) has evolved into Social and Behaviour Change Communication (SBCC), which is research based interactive and planned process aimed at changing social conditions and individual behaviours. Social change communication involves strategic use of advocacy, media, interpersonal and dialogue-based communication, and social mobilisation to systematically accelerate change in the underlying drivers of certain health risks, social vulnerability and impact. It requires an assessment of the specific nature of these drivers in order to design an appropriate response.

Social and Behaviour Change Communication (SBCC) engage both top-down and bottom-up communication in absorbing communities, building on local wisdom, expanding horizontal communication (i.e., communication that occurs between individuals operating at the same “level”) and through increased access to media. It is a process of community dialogue and collective action through which the community itself identifies priorities, develops a vision and plan of action, and mobilises internal and external resources to carry it out. Every time a community goes through this process, changes in both individual outcomes (such as increased knowledge and healthier behaviour) as well as social outcomes (such as strengthened community leadership, broader participation, and social cohesion) are expected to occur.

Mass media play a crucial role in spreading information and influencing public opinion. New Media has especially helped to create a more interconnected world by overcoming space time barriers. The emerging networks, linking individuals and communities are offering both new advantages and challenges to social justice

movements around the world. The case studies discussed in the unit will focus on how communication is used to bring about social and behaviour change in the society. In this unit, we shall discuss some select case studies related to agriculture, population, health education, governance and gender issues using Social and Behaviour Change Communication.

17.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this unit, you should be able to:

- critically analyse some case studies using Social and Behaviour Change Communication (SBCC) in the areas of governance, health, environment, gender issues, education and agriculture; and
- apply some of these strategies for designing campaigns in your area of interest.

17.2 ENVIRONMENT

The environment, as you know consists of our surroundings, which include the trees, plants, flower, waterfalls, forests, mountains, water, air etc. We need a clean environment for our well-being and living a healthy life. As such, polluted environment in the form of unhygienic surroundings, excessive emission of toxic materials and non-degradable waste, makes our surrounding unsafe to live. We will now examine a case study on community participation on clean surrounding.

Today, lack of cleanliness in cities poses a serious environmental challenge. Realising these consequences, EXNORA International of Chennai, started off as a club of concerned citizens, who took this challenge upon themselves to clean up their city. The concept of CIVIC EXNORA was introduced first in Adyar area of Chennai in October 1988. The primary objective of EXNORA was to generate ideas, create civic and environmental awareness among the citizens and provide a service to the public, which would turn these novel and radical ideas into practice.

It all started as a trial, when the Corporation chose to experiment with hydro-containers at Kamaraj Avenue in Adyar and EXNORA got involved in the collection of garbage. In this experiment, garbage was to be directly placed into the hydro-containers so that Corporation workers could later mount them directly on trucks. These hydro-containers were made available at the end of every street so that the garbage could be directly dumped and not strewn in and around the dustbins. The residents found it inconvenient to carry the garbage from their respective houses to the end of the streets for disposal. EXNORA worked with the local residents and came up with an innovative yet simple and practical solution. Thus was born the Civic EXNORA movement through this experiment after successfully working hand in hand with the Corporation.

EXNORA further used this model to promote the idea of community involvement in collection and transportation of garbage. The system is based on people's participation through local neighbourhood committees. The residents who generated garbage got together to collectively solve the problem of solid waste accumulation, by removing and relocating it, in an identified dumping place.

Today, there are about 5,000 such Civic Exnoras in Chennai city and in the various Districts of Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka and Kerala and a few other states of the country, covering about 30,000 streets and settlements.

The Chennai City alone having 2000 Civic Exnoras translates this Waste Management into a Rs 30,00,000 turn over in the informal Solid Waste Management Sector per month which amounts to a turnover of Rs 3.6 crores per annum. The Waste Management of an area is under the purview of the local authority. Exnora has brought about the enactment of Municipal Solid Waste (Management and Handling) Rules 2000 through the Public Interest Litigation filed by Exnora in the Supreme Court.

Since the start, these practices have been replicated and implemented in many places. The replication and sustainability of the practices was ensured through awareness and motivation of communities resulting in behaviour change among the citizens, which was followed by encouragement and active involvement. Adopting this model has further helped in spreading the message and assisted the communities to easily introduce major Zero Waste Management

Concepts.

Another remarkable example of the Social and Behaviour Change Communication is the Clean India or Swachh Bharat Abhiyan, where it focuses on changing the mindsets and acknowledging the right of every citizen to a clean and healthy environment. The campaign was launched by the Prime Minister of India, Shri Narendra Modi on 2nd of October 2014 and sets an ambitious goal to make India 'clean' by 2nd of October 2019. The key components of the campaign include construction of toilets, elimination of manual scavenging, solid waste management, and converting waste into wealth.

The World Bank reports that 53% Indian households still defecate in the open, and over 20 percent of the toilets constructed are reported to be not in use (Government of India, 2013) which poses a threat to the sanitation and health aspect of the people. Currently, more than 2.5 billion people worldwide lack access to toilets, one billion people practice open defecation and over 600 million in India openly defecate. Poor sanitation and lack of access to toilets are detrimental for public health, the environment and the economy of the country.

Since its country wide launch, industry leaders, political parties, religious groups as well as civil society organisations, irrespective of their ideologies have endorsed the campaign and are collectively working for its success. Celebrities, including actors and sportspersons, have pledged to work for Swachh Bharat Mission and have set exemplary roles by taking part in the Mission. Youth and citizens across the country are actively participating in the campaign and learning to keep their environment clean and healthy.

Having separate guidelines for both rural and urban areas, the endeavour of the Swachh Bharat Campaign is to turn into a mass movement, focusing not just on toilets but also on behavioural changes regarding healthy sanitation practices among the citizens of the country. For this, the Central Government has used different media to create awareness on the Clean India campaign and has also earmarked Rs.1800 crore for an intensive Information, Education and Communication (IEC) mission for behavioural changes. The IEC mission envisions creating awareness about the need for cleanliness and realising the

much needed behavioural changes among the citizens of India. Capacity building plans for undertaking the intensive behaviour change activities at the grassroots level have also been rolled out by the states.

Since the inception of Swachh Bharat in 2014, over 9.17 crore toilets have been built, more than 5.43 lakh villages have been declared Open Defecation Free (ODF), 594 districts declared ODF and 27 States and Union Territories declared ODF. The campaign is an ongoing process and with the support and initiative of the citizens, the country can attain the Swachh Bharat Mission.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What is Social and Behaviour Change Communication (SBCC)?

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2. Why SBCC is needed in Environment protection?

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3. What are the key components of Clean India or Swachh Bharat Campaign?

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17.3 AGRICULTURE

Agriculture has remained the mainstay of human existence since time immemorial. With the passage of time, agricultural practices have also evolved into different forms. Scientific ways of farming have helped farmers yield better crops and high productivity. However, in many parts of the world including in rural India, farmers hesitate to adopt modern technologies and prefer to use age old practices passed down from generation to generation. This kind of attitude hampers the introduction of latest scientific technologies and usages.

In order to educate farmers about scientific ways of farming, a number of successful campaigns have been taken up in agricultural sector using different forms of media. The role of mass media in agriculture has become indispensable. Television, Radio and Print media are used to educate both literate and illiterate farmers to boost their agricultural practices. Nowadays, different Mobile applications (apps) are introduced for the farming communities wherein they can update themselves on the latest farming technologies, farming methods, marketing and agricultural schemes of the government. Rural farmers still rely on radio as an important source of information on agriculture. Farm radios are also developed by different organisations to help the farmers by giving them inputs on farming.

The Government of India through its Information and Broadcasting wing has introduced the FM Kisan Vani Stations in the country and the Kisan TV channel in Doordarshan. It has initiated the Kisan Channel in collaboration with the Ministry of Agriculture, Government of India. The FM Kisan Vani is playing an important role in supporting the Agriculture Extension in the country. All India Radio has documented success stories of farmers listening to FM Kisan Vani, where farmers from different parts of the country have given their testimonials on successful farming.

One such example is that of Hema Ananth, whose primary occupation is flower cultivation and rearing animals and dairy farming as the secondary occupation. Hema being an undergraduate wanted to convert 10 acres of wasteland into a fertile land. She developed an interest in listening to FM Kisan Vani and regarded it as a guru and followed everything that was instructed in the radio programmes. She became an avid listener of Akashvani, Hassan and learned from the experiences of other progressive farmers on organic cultivation and natural cropping. The programmes inspired her to act with proper planning and caution. Hema became a successful farmer with the knowledge acquired from Kisan Vani and an expert in rose cultivation, marketing and value addition. The Department of Agriculture, Government of Karnataka provided her financial assistance for promoting organic cultivation.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. Why is the role of mass media in agriculture important?

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2. What role did media play for Hema Ananth's success in farming?

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17.4 POPULATION

India is projected to have the largest population in the world by 2045, surpassing China. The latest UN projections say India will have two billion people by 2101 if the population continues to grow at the current rate. Stabilising population is an essential requirement for promoting sustainable development with more equitable distribution. In the early 1950s, the Government of India launched a family welfare programme, whose main objective was to spread the knowledge of family planning method and encourage people for adopting contraceptive methods. The programme was accorded special priority during the 1960s and 1970s but could not catch up to its desired goals. Various factors such as socio-economic status, ethnicity, quality of health care services decision making roles etc. influenced contraceptive choices and use. The programme was later expanded and became the Reproductive Health programme. A project carried out by the United Nations Population Fund in Rajasthan in 1993 called, 'Jan Mangal' a community-based contraceptive distribution intervention was piloted in two districts of Alwar and Udiapur in 1993 and later scaled up and replicated in all districts in the state.

Rajasthan recorded a high rate of population during 1951-1991 followed by low acceptance of spacing methods, high infant mortality rates and lack of adequate knowledge of contraceptive methods. There was also a lack of communication between the Auxiliary Nurse Midwives (ANMs) and the general public. The Jan Mangal project was initiated with the aim to create awareness about different methods of contraception, break the socio cultural barriers in contraceptive use and to influence behaviour change among the community. The programme was carried out by Jan Mangal couples (husband and wife) recruited by the ANMs after consultation with the community members on voluntary basis.

The Jan Mangal couples were trained to counsel other couples on spacing methods and ill effects of child and maternal health due to frequent pregnancies. The barrier to poor communication was broken as Jan Mangal couples educated and counseled other couples on contraception methods through intra-personal communication. The couples were selected primarily because they could easily communicate with their community members and also relate with other couples in the village. Earlier due to lack of knowledge, the villagers were not aware of the usage of contraceptive methods and maternal health care, resulting in high rate of population and maternal and infant mortality. The project involved active participation by the community volunteers. The intervention was found to be useful in increasing the level of awareness on the usage of contraceptive methods and make services easily accessible to the villages.

Another approach towards family planning and reproductive health have been innovative public awareness campaigns, like the Condom Bindaas Bol Campaign. Launched in India in September 2006, Condom Bindaas Bol Campaign was a collaborative initiative of USAID, Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, PACT CRH and other stakeholders. The main objective of the campaign was to expand the declining condom use and sales in Northern India, address the stigma surrounding condom use and decrease the embarrassment associated with purchasing condoms. The campaign encouraged people to talk openly about condoms and not hesitate in freely using the word at the time of purchase.

Formative research conducted prior to the launch of the campaign revealed that the subject of condoms remains a taboo topic that most people were uncomfortable discussing about. A strategy was hence developed to “normalise” the condom, positioning it as any other product used by normal people and reduce the discomfort people felt when saying the word ‘condom’.

Using a 360-degree approach, the campaign targeted both consumers and vendors. A combination of communication channels and approaches were used including traditional and non-traditional media, public relations initiatives, and other activities. To promote the campaign, a series of powerful TV advertisements were aired along with numerous stories about the campaign and condoms on key television channels and in the print media.

The mass media efforts were supported by contests that invited people to re-enact the television advertisement in towns across the states. Retailers, consumers, as well as celebrities all participated to create greater impact and “buzz” about the campaign. Contest winners were given prizes by celebrities supporting the “Bindaas Bol” campaign. The male celebrities did pro bono re-enacting of the advertisements, and gave interviews about the campaign and why they chose to endorse it. The retailer’s enthusiastic participation led to “wallpapering” their shops with “Bindaas Bol” and other condom promotion materials.

To supplement the mass media activities, “Bindaas Bol” partnered with condom marketers to enhance visibility and access and conducted sensitisation sessions for over 40,000 health care providers (chemists, retailers stocking condoms, and indigenous medical practitioners) through project field representatives on the importance of correct and consistent use of condoms.

Evaluations done after completion of the campaign contend that the programme proved to be an effective way of increasing the total condom market in North India and of changing attitudes towards use and users of condoms. The numerous partnerships developed with the private and commercial sectors and celebrities over the course of the campaign were crucial in leveraging cash and in-kind contribution and the success of the campaign. The campaign won several accolades and inspired the design of other such campaigns.

17.5 EDUCATION

Education is one of the most important tools for change and development. The constitutional commitment of free and compulsory education to all children up to 14 years of age has made education a very important goal, especially in the rural areas. Community participation in schools is seen to be a successful process, wherein, the community has taken the initiative of looking into the affairs of the school, students and teachers as a whole. It has become more formalised in policy in recent years with new forms of community participation emerging. Community schools involve the community in construction and management of schools, through funds and assistance from the government.

Community participation is particularly significant at the primary level. The formation of school committees is an important way in which community involvement is being promoted in many countries. Several studies report that community schools are successful in improving access to schooling, and also that girls’ participation in schooling in particular has improved.

Nagaland, a small state in the Northeastern part of India is credited for its unique concept on Communitisation of Public Institutions and Services. The Government of Nagaland enacted the 'Nagaland Communitisation of Public Institutions and Services Act' in 2002 to cover water, power supply and education sectors. The Act empowers community to own, manage and control these sectors as their own, vesting in them legal powers and responsibilities. In the education sector, which is a partnership between Government and the community, the programme seeks to develop institutions of excellence with active participation of the community. Communitisation has helped open a channel of communication between the government and the community. Agendas of the community can be addressed directly to the Government for appraisal for improving the standard of education and other facilities.

All Government-run Primary and Middle Schools have been communitised, empowering the community to manage elementary schools in respect to academic, administrative and financial responsibilities. The community receives funds for key purposes such as purchase of textbooks, furniture repair and maintenance of school buildings etc. A sense of ownership and responsibility is developed among the communities and they take active participation by contributing generously in cash and kind, besides the government-aided facilities. The community has also participated in improving the poor and run-down infrastructures such as buildings and educational facilities. As a result of this social change initiative, the community created a sense of ownership among the young and the old to preserve and care for the school buildings and other facilities.

Following the enactment of this Act, 205 elementary schools covering 90 villages were covered as a pilot project in 2002. In the second phase, 197 schools covering 128 villages were communitised in 2003 and at present, all government schools have been communitised. Many rural children who were engaged in agriculture and child labour were motivated to attend schools, which resulted in an overwhelming response in the school enrollment.

Regular inspections, parent-teacher-community interactions are held, the quantity and quality of mid-day meal scheme is also monitored along with the maintenance of proper teacher attendance and their conduct in schools. Proxy teachers are disallowed and the concept of 'no work no pay' has also paid dividends since Village Education Committees have deducted salaries of teachers for unauthorised absence from classes.

Intensive awareness campaigns were carried out at all levels. Mass media played a big role in creating awareness among the communities on the concept of communitisation. Documentary films and radio programmes were developed to educate the communities and extensive news coverage was given on communitisation. The concept of communitisation has been successfully implemented in all the rural areas of Nagaland, thereby bringing about a social change for quality education through the participation of the community. It has also awakened the competitive spirits of the communities, thereby reducing the wide inter-district variations in education. Many schools reported improvement in academic performance and produced toppers in the Class 4 board exams.

The state government, realising the success of the experience, has upgraded many primary schools to middle schools. The communitisation process has also been extended in urban areas with the setting up of Ward Education Committees.

According to an official report released by the State government, communitisation has helped in improvement in enrolment, students' academic performance and attendance while there is substantial reduction of school dropouts and proxy teachers, including corruption and irregularities in school functioning.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What kind of communication approach was used by the Jan Mangals to educate people on family planning methods?

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2. What is communitisation and why is it important?

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17.6 HEALTH

In Vietnam, a project was funded by USAID and supported by Family Health International (FHI) for decentralised and comprehensive Behaviour Change Communication (BCC) campaign, which was carried out in four provinces viz; Hai Phong, Can Tho, Quang Ninh and Binh Dinh in May 2000. The local governments and mass organisations were involved in implementing the interventions, under the guidance of FHI. The BCC project included basic, intensive and advanced training and ongoing technical support from FHI for building local capacity in the BCC campaigns.

The IEC centers of Provincial Health Services played a key role in the development of materials and for training for interpersonal communication through peer and health educators. Local artists and writers were engaged to participate in the campaign with tailor made messages to reflect local realities and reach their target populations. The reasons for initiating the BCC campaign were as follows;

- To upgrade the knowledge, skills and practices of communication practitioners so that BCC strategies and activities are more effective.
- To improve audiences' HIV/STI knowledge, to encourage changes in behaviour and build skills for safer practices.

- To increase the acceptance of condom use for STI/HIV prevention among people whose sexual or injecting behaviour puts them at risk of HIV.
- To convince men to be more responsible in sexual health matters in their roles as citizens, fathers, husbands, friends, and employees.

During the course of the campaign, different activities were carried out in the form of formative research in the initial stage to explore knowledge, behaviours, attitudes and needs linked to HIV prevention Advocacy Meetings with community and party leaders. In the process, workshops and trainings were organised for barbers, shoeshine boys, motorcycle taxi drivers and workplace. Television and radio spots/tele-dramas productions were used during the campaign. Condom promotion through social marketing at non-traditional outlets, mass media advertising and media events were organised.

The outcome of the BCC campaign saw significant results in fostering institutional autonomy and sustainability by strengthening provincial capacity to design activities and HIV/AIDS prevention messages, to locally produce materials and to select and prepare appropriate mass media and interpersonal channels. Both Government bodies and mass organisations collaborated to successfully implement community-based activities which otherwise was traditionally carried out by NGOs in other countries in the region. A remarkable outcome was also the dynamic and successful decentralisation of BCC campaign at the provincial level in terms of design, pre-testing materials, production and dissemination of BCC messages through both mass media and interpersonal communication (peer education) approaches.

The BCC campaign reached over 150,000 people through FHI-supported interpersonal one-on-one peer education HIV/AIDS prevention activities and the BCC messages on HI/AIDS prevention reached literally millions of people through provincial and nation-wide broadcasts of tele-dramas, radio and TV spots, FHI-sponsored HIV/AIDS concerts, social events, World AIDS Day events, and provincial and national advertising for condom promotion.

17.7 GENDER ISSUES

Various studies have revealed that the empowerment of women, through education, literacy, employment and economic opportunities, has positive consequences for society as a whole, including the women themselves, their children, their whole family and the community (Sen, 1999; Parker, 2005). Healthy, educated and empowered women are able to contribute to the socio-economic development of the society more effectively. In a society where women are empowered through education and employment and where women participate in decision-making processes on all levels of society, there is generally an increased emphasis on values such as peace, social justice, equality, human rights and ecological sustainability, than in patriarchal societies (Jeong, 2000, Bell, 2006). Gender-based oppression; inequality, social injustice and poverty are forms of structural violence. Many women in today's world are victims of gender-based violence, as they encounter direct and indirect forms of violence, through unjust and oppressive social systems. Women have been promoting a 'culture of peace' by working with social and "global issues such as development, democracy, human rights, world security and the environment" (Yesufu, 2000). Thus, it is important to focus on the empowerment of women as well as on the potential of

women's agency for social change. In this regard, let us examine the case study of the Gulabi Gang of India.

The Gulabi Gang is a movement formed by a group of women in 2006 to fight various forms of social injustice. The leader of the group named Sampat Pal Devi came from Banda District of Uttar Pradesh, which is regarded as one of the poorest districts in India. The state is known for its patriarchal culture, rigid caste divisions, female illiteracy, domestic violence, child labour, child marriages and dowry demands. The women's group is popularly known as Gulabi or 'Pink' Gang because the members wear bright pink saris and wield bamboo sticks. They protect the powerless from abuse and fight corruption to ensure basic rights of the poor in rural areas and discourage traditions like child-marriages. Today, the Gulabi Gang has tens of thousands of women members, several male supporters and many successful interventions to their credit. Sampat Devi organises meetings with different people and network with those who are ready to fight for a cause. She not only educates the people through her eloquent speeches but also sings folk songs to "uproot the corrupt and be self reliant", and animatedly talks to women and men who flock to her with their problems. The gang ensures proper public distribution of food-grains to people below the poverty line, disbursement of pension to elderly widows who have no birth certificate to prove their age, and prevent abuse of women and children.

The Gulabi Gang experience shows how a mixture of traditional communication mediums in the form of speeches, folk-tunes and visual communication symbolised through colours in attires and demonstrations can be a powerful strategy for social change. The case study shows the potential of how the empowerment of women can lead to social change and transforming systems of violence and gender-based oppression into gender equality.

Check Your Progress 4

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What was the outcome of BCC in the HIV campaign?

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2. Describe how the Gulabi Gang members used communication for change.

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17.8 GOVERNANCE

Good governance, economic, social and political development continuous to be a big challenge today. Freedom of Information in any democratic society is a core principle of good governance as it enables citizens to understand and participate in public affairs and also holds those in public office accountable for their decisions, actions or non- actions.

The media occupies a critical place in the governance process and plays a vital role as a gatekeeper; disseminating critical messages to the public and highlighting issues/concerns/ initiatives and ultimately creating social change through its communication strategies. Ever since the inception of Right to Information (RTI) Act, the media has been playing a pro-active role in disseminating awareness and bringing about huge social change in the country. Right to Information Act 2005 mandates timely response to citizen requests for government information.

NDTV launched a nationwide campaign on RTI in partnership with civil society organisation to build public awareness on RTI. People were discouraged from paying bribes and without any fear ask for information under the RTI Act to solve their problems. Doordarshan, the State owned broadcast network also launched a weekly half-hour programme on Right to Information to present best examples of how the common man has used the power of RTI and create awareness through the programme. The Indian Express has also been guiding people in exercising their right to information through a column – “Express Initiatives”. It has not only reported cases of success and failure in use of the Right to Information Act but also published sample ‘questions’ to assist citizens in framing ‘well drafted’ questions. In addition to this column, the Indian Express has organised awareness camps and training workshops in association with other institutions to guide people in accessing information.

Social activities are also making use of social media to educate the people on RTI Act. One such initiative is that of Raju Inamdar from Purandar Taluka in Pune, who is a part of an audio-CD released by NGO Masoom to raise awareness on the institution of local-self governing bodies. The four-minute song asks villagers to use the RTI to pave the way for an informed citizenry to ensure transparency and strengthen the fabric of democracy.

The song, which starts with a brief introduction on the procedure of filing RTI applications and general benefits of the RTI Act, terms the RTI as a right that would enrich the lives of many. The song reads that developmental works like construction of roads and digging of wells should not remain on paper. You have to monitor the work and also the spending on it, through RTI. The song has reached several villages in Maharashtra online and has become a powerful tool of communication. Many villagers, who could not understand RTI Act, could now understand the Act because of the song, which was composed in local language.

Activity-1

You have been appointed as a Consultant for Behavioural Communication Change for RTI. Design a short media campaign to create awareness on RTI Act in your state. Use the following grid to develop a BCC plan of action.

Identify the audience	Risk/problem area	Messages	Channel of Communication (choose the easily available channel)	Activities
Primary				
Secondary				
Tertiary				

17.9 LET US SUM UP

In this unit, you studied various case studies on Social and Behaviour Change Communication (SBCC) and examined how SBCC can influence policy makers, stakeholders, community and individuals to bring about tangible changes in the society. It was discussed that the change in community's role in leadership patterns, initiating a dialogue about problems and having a consensus opinion will improve a community's problem and create a sustainable livelihood for the people without any apprehensions and doubt. You studied how a sense of ownership is related to community's feeling that the programme belongs to them and they have a commitment to the programme. You also learned the role of mass media in Agriculture extension and how it can influence the farming community in embracing innovative ideas and technologies. Further, you learnt that social cohesion consists of forces, which act as members of a group or community to actively contribute to the group thereby resulting in productivity of a given programme. SBCC is being extensively used in Poshan Abhiyan, Beti Bachao Beti Padhao and similar initiatives.

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17.11 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. Social and behavioural change communication is an umbrella term involving strategic use of advocacy, media, interpersonal and dialogue- based communication, and social mobilisation to systematically accelerate change. The characteristics of Social and Behaviour Change Communication are:

- 1) It is an interactive, researched and planned process.

- 2) It relates to socio-ecological model.
 - 3) It operates through three key strategies, viz, advocacy, social mobilisation and behaviour change communication.
2. Social and Behaviour Change Communication is needed for environmental protection because human behaviour is related to environmental degradation and changing the behaviour will entail efforts in conserving the environment.
 3. The key components of the Clean India campaign include construction of toilets, elimination of manual scavenging, solid waste management, and converting waste into wealth.

Check Your Progress 2

1. The role of mass media in agriculture has become very important. Television, Radio and Print media are used to educate both literate and illiterate farmers to boost their agricultural practices. Farmers rely on mass media to get information on innovative ideas, technologies and different forms of farming. Mass media has helped farmers in giving right information on seasonal crops, weather updates, sowing techniques, farm technologies etc.
2. Radio played a very important role in Hema Ananth's life as a successful farmer. She developed an interest in listening to FM Kisan Vani and followed everything that was instructed in the radio programmes. She learned from the experiences of other progressive farmers on organic cultivation and natural cropping. The programmes inspired her to act with proper planning and caution. Hema became a successful farmer with the knowledge acquired from Kisan Vani and an expert in rose cultivation, marketing and value addition.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) The Jan Mangal couples were trained to counsel other couples on spacing methods and ill-effects of child and maternal health due to frequent pregnancies. The barrier to poor communication was broken as Jan Mangal couples educated and counseled other couples on contraception methods through intra-personal communication. These couples known as the Jan Mangals were selected as the communicators, because they could easily communicate with their community and also relate with other couples in the village.
- 2) Communitisation consists of a unique partnership between the government and the community with the aim of improving the delivery of public utility systems. It involves transfer of ownership of public resources and assets, control over service delivery, empowerment, decentralisation, delegation and capacity building.

Check Your Progress 4

- 1) The outcome of the BCC campaign saw tremendous results in fostering institutional autonomy and sustainability by strengthening provincial capacity to design activities and HIV/AIDS prevention messages, to locally produce materials and to select and prepare appropriate mass media and interpersonal channels. Both Government bodies and mass organisations collaborated to

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successfully implement community- based activities which otherwise was traditionally carried out by NGOs in other countries in the region. A remarkable outcome was also the dynamic and successful decentralisation of BCC campaign at the provincial level in terms of design, pre-testing materials, production and dissemination of BCC messages through both mass media and interpersonal communication (peer education) approaches.

- 2) The Gulabi Gang members used a mix of traditional communication mediums in the form of speeches, folk-tunes and visual communication symbolised through colours in attires and demonstrations for social change.



UNIT 18 ALTERNATIVE MEDIA

Structure

- 18.0 Introduction
- 18.1 Learning Outcomes
- 18.2 What is Alternative media?
- 18.3 Mainstream Media
- 18.4 Alternative Media in India
 - 18.4.1 Folk Media
 - 18.4.2 Small-Scale Newspapers
 - 18.4.3 Community Video
 - 18.4.4 Community Radio
 - 18.4.5 Citizen Journalism
- 18.5 New Media and Alternative Media
 - 18.5.1 Independent New Websites
 - 18.5.2 Social Media as Alternative Media
- 18.6 Future of Alternative Media
- 18.7 Let Us Sum Up
- 18.8 References and Further Readings
- 18.9 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

18.0 INTRODUCTION

This is the last unit of the course Media and Society in which we shall discuss the concept of alternative media and explain how it is different from the mainstream media. We shall examine different forms of alternative media such as folk media, small scale newspapers, community radio, community video and citizen journalism and their relevance in the present context. We shall also look at new media and social media as alternative platforms and examine the issues related to credibility of the content on social media. The section on future of alternative media throws light on the usage of technological advancements which can change the alternative media discourse and lead to appropriate action by concerned authorities.

18.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this unit you should be able to:

- define alternative media;
- compare the business model of mainstream media with alternative media;
- discuss different forms of alternative media;
- describe the relationship between new media and alternative media; and
- discuss the future of alternative media in India.

18.2 WHAT IS ALTERNATIVE MEDIA?

Let us first try to understand the meaning of the word 'alternative'. According to the Oxford English Dictionary alternative (in this context) means available as another possibility or different from what is usual or traditional. When do we look for alternatives in our lives? We generally look for alternatives in our lives when we are dissatisfied with the current option available to us. For example, if you are disappointed with the performance of your mobile phone; you start looking for alternative mobile phone or any other alternative arrangement which can enhance the performance of your mobile phone.

Similarly, alternative media is 'another possibility to the mainstream media'. Alternative media can be any medium - newspaper, magazine, newsletter, radio, TV, films, new media, wall paintings, graffiti, street art which provides an alternative to the mainstream media. In other words we can say when the mainstream media creates discontent and dissatisfaction; the audience look for alternative sources of information (media) which provides them relevant information and different interpretation. They either become the producer or the consumer of the alternative media.

In their book "Manufacturing Consent" Herman and Chomsky (1998) have mentioned the evolution of radical press in first half of the nineteenth century in Great Britain. "This alternative press was effective in reinforcing class consciousness; it unified the workers because it fostered an alternative value system and framework for looking at the world" which encouraged them to collective action. At one time this radical press became a threat to mainstream media as well as to the legislature. Alternative media differs in content, production and distribution from the mainstream media. It should be noted here that alternative media should not be seen as opposite to the mainstream but considered as a platform where opinions of all shades and pluralistic views are accommodated. The alternative media aims to voice different opinions rather than enunciating only popular or adverse opinion of the mainstream media.

While discussing the concept of 'gatekeepers' in previous units you would have read that gatekeepers in mainstream media have their limitations as well as vested interests for highlighting, down playing or even ignoring particular issue. In contrast, the alternative media provides freedom to voice different opinions to surface which are rejected or downplayed by mainstream media.

German philosopher and sociologist Jurgen Habermas, outlined the concept of 'public sphere' which is conceived as a social space in which different opinions are expressed, general problems discussed, and collective solutions developed, that may even influence political action. A vibrant public sphere is the central arena for societal communication, however, what are the discourses and who participates and voices their opinions in the public sphere is a key issue. Habermas's public sphere has been replaced by virtual world wherein a great deal of discussion and debates have influenced political action. Recently, India Against Corruption, Nirbhaya movement are a few classic examples of public discussion and debate which lead to political action. Even individual tweets to ministers lead to political action and follow up.

Certain radical groups of Maoists and Naxals publish their newspaper and enunciate discontent in the society; Awami Jung, known as Jung, is one such

internal journal of the Maoist party in India. Some student groups/unions at University or college level also exploit different forms of alternative media to express their views and dissent in the system. The Student federation of India publishes 'Student Struggle' monthly in English and 'Chatra Sangrash' in Hindi and many other in regional languages to spread their voice and unite the students for social transformation. Internationally, Julian Assange's Wiki Leaks is a popular example of exposing the misdoings of various Governments and Corporate sector. *Democracy Now!* is independent award-winning news programme hosted by journalists Amy Goodman and Juan Gonzales in the United States of America. It is a national programme which is distributed through various online and offline media platforms (refer to <http://www.democracynow.org> for more information).

Seema Mustafa, senior journalist and political commentator views that alternative media is smaller in comparison to mainstream media but "it can connect with the rural, is committed to the poor and the oppressed and reports the truth". She believes that in the past quarter century media has undergone tremendous changes and "the takeover of the corporates has resulted in a total disconnect of the real India from the mainstream media", hence the need for alternative media.

Berrigan's (1979) identifies two critical concepts of alternative media: access and participation. Access refers to the availability of communication tools and resources for local community members to express themselves collectively or individually, irrespective of geography, class, ethnicity, or gender. Participation on the other hand focus upon two aspects, the involvement of the community in media processes of design, production, and implementation as well as the level of peoples engagement, ranging from tokenism to full ownership of processes on the other (Fairbairn 2009; Berrigan 1979). Several scholars also point towards the locally and culturally relevant content of Community media as its defining aspect.

Audiences' identification with the producers of local content of community media builds trust and credibility of content.

Carpentier, Lie and Servaes identify the following characteristics of alternative media with reference to mainstream media:

- Small scale and oriented towards specific communities, possibly disadvantaged groups, respecting their diversity;
- Independent of state and market;
- Horizontally structured, allowing for the facilitation of audience access and participation within the frame of democratisation and multiplicity;
- Carriers of non-dominant discourses and representations, stressing the importance of self representation.

They further advocate a rhizomatic view of community/ alternative media as it tends to cut across borders and build linkages and connections among civil society, other community media, the state and the market, to serve the interest of the community they serve without losing their identity and diminishing the rigidities and certainties of public and commercial media organisations and highlighting the fluidity and contingency of community media organisations.

Listed below are some alternative media platforms. You may browse their websites to get acquainted with their functions and activities:

- Woman's Community Radio
- World Pulse Magazine
- GAMCOTRAP
- NYC Grassroots Media Coalition
- Black Music Radio or Pirate Radio
- Indy Media
- OneWorld.net
- Jay's Leftist & "Progressive
- Community Broadcasting Online
- Australian Community Radio and Television
- Alternative Radio
- The Common Dreams News Center
- ZNet and the Alternative Press Review
- Global Voices Online
- Good News Agency

In the light of above discussion, we may define alternative media as "a small-scale, independent, grassroot media which encourage alternative discourse to highlight the marginalised section of society." It is people's media which is run largely by community for the benefit of their own community. Thus, alternative media is by the people, for the people, and of the people.

18.3 MAINSTREAM MEDIA

Herman and Chomsky (1997) have compared mainstream media to elite media, "sometimes called the agenda-setting media because they are the ones with the big resources, they set the framework in which everyone else operates". They emphasised the five filters of propaganda model which have trapped the media professionals so much that no one is able to see the biasness in the reports. These filters are:

- The ownership pattern: who owns media, its size, type of ownership, wealth involved, and profit making;
- Dependency of mainstream media on the advertising revenue;
- Relying on information provided by government, business and expert by mainstream media (at times funded and approved by them);
- Flak and enforcers; and
- Anti-communism as control mechanism.

The ownership pattern of mainstream media plays crucial role in defining its content which serve the interest of dominant ideology of the system. The mainstream media is big media and demand huge resources which corporate houses are best placed to cater. Generally, corporate houses run mainstream media but there are some exceptions in our country where mainstream media is controlled by families and politician and political parties too. The mainstream media runs on a business model and the latest trends reflect a growing tendency to maximise

the profit. With the intervention of corporate culture news has been turned into a commodity, which like any other product in market needs to be marketed, packaged and presented in scintillating way to the audience. This commodification of news is largely centred around the personal views of the prime time television news anchors. This trend has further eroded mainstream media's role to express alternative views and dissent voices.

Senior journalist, P. Sainath argues that “it depends on what the media presume as their social role. Today for instance, the media see their role as a representation of the corporate world as it believes in its ideology. In a different time, in a different period, Indian journalism was a child of the freedom struggle”. He also points out that “increasingly the media now function as stenographers to the powerful”. According to him the Indian media is politically free but they are hemmed in the profit making and still ruled by the elite ideologies.

Scholars working in the area lay stress not only on the alternative media content but also on the alternative corporate structure or an alternative business model which supports the objective of alternative media and does not dilute the content and information. They argue that the business model should not be profit-centric but focused on social change and development.

Thus it can be argued that mainstream media stands for status quo while alternative media roots for change. When the mainstream media fails to perform its responsibilities, a vacuum is created in the society wherein people long for authentic information without prejudices of the media house. The alternative media aims to address the information needs of audience and provide them information reflecting alternative opinion and perspectives.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. Define alternative media.

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2. Why mainstream media is also known as elite media?

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3. List five areas on which alternative and mainstream media largely differ.

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18.4 ALTERNATIVE MEDIA IN INDIA

In India, the concept of alternative media is still evolving and is seen more as an anti-establishment and radical media. Sainath, however, argues that the existence of alternative media in India can be traced back to our pre-independence days when Indian media acted as the alternative media to the ruling British media. At that time, many underground press and radio stations were functional; many small regional language newspapers were regularly published in support of the nationalist movement to topple down the British raj. The states with high literacy rates such as Kerala were able to establish regional newspapers and presses which contributed to the national awakening.

In this section, we shall look at some alternative media forms in India such as folk media, street theatre, small newspapers, community video and radio among others.

18.4.1 Folk Media

Folk media is considered to be the most important alternative media in the rural India. It is the oldest form of entertainment and information in our country. Folk media took its shape and form as per the culture of a region. For instance, Nautanki from UP, Bhavai of Gujarat, Tamasha of Maharashtra, Jatra from West Bengal, Rajasthan's famous Puppetry show, Ramleela and Rasleela are performed in various states. In modern India in various cities and colleges Nukkad Natak or Street Play became prominent folk medium to reach out to people with social messages.

Street plays have evolved a lot since past three decades and have become voice of various radical groups. In 1940's, one of its kind alternative medium was started in the form of Indian People's Theatre Association (IPTA) by the Communist party of India, which still exists. The primary objective of IPTA was to bring social reforms and to act against British repression. They disseminated their messages through the medium of theatre and made people aware about their rights and responsibilities. IPTA highlighted the issues that were ignored by the national media in the wake of the freedom struggle. Many popular names, including KA Abbas, Dr. Homi Bhabha, Ismat Chughtai, Sahir Ludhianvi and many more were members of IPTA and they worked hand-in-hand with common people to bring about change. The Government of India after independence realised the prominence of folk/traditional media and established Song and Drama Division. This unit works at grassroot level and promotes Government programmes and policies through live and direct folk performances.

Feminist author Urvashi Butalia (1993) in her case study, “Women and Alternative Media (India) discussed various alternative platforms available to women in India. She highlighted how Kerala Shastra Sahitya Parishad (KSSP) had used Yatra as an outreach tool for engaging the audience by using various tools such as public speaking, puppetry, songs, plays, posters etc. “Save Narmada Yatra” was a campaign on similar lines against building of Narmada and Saradar Sarovar Dam in Central India. Another medium was street theater, a play – “Om Swahs” by Delhi based women group ‘Stree Shakti’ against dowry highlighting the plight of women who could not bring enough dowry.

Activity-1

Identify a folk media of your region and explain how it acts as an alternative medium.

18.4.2 Small-Scale Newspapers

Initially, alternative media in India was largely limited to the small newspapers and magazines circulated by some radical groups. Khabar Lahariya is one such newspaper started by a Delhi based NGO - “Nirantar” in 2002. It is an eight page weekly publication from Uttar Pradesh and Bihar written in multiple local dialects and it covers the functioning of panchayats, government, schools, hospitals, social issues, civil issues in the region. Women from the marginalised sections of society with little or no formal education are provided training to report, edit, design, illustrate, and take photographs for the newspaper. They even distribute newspaper via small shops, tea stalls and block headquarters. According to khabarlahariya.org “it has 40 members, Khabar Lahariya team sells 6000 copies across 600 villages of Uttar Pradesh and Bihar to a readership of 80,000 per week. Khabar Lahariya began as the only Bundeli newspaper in India and now has editions in Bhojpuri, Awadhi, Hindustani and Bajjika”.

18.4.3 Community Video

On similar lines, in 2007 Appan Samachar, an all-women community news channel was started by Mr. Santosh Sarang in Ramlila Gachi, Muzafarpur, Bihar. The village girls were trained to undertake various activities related to news production on their own. The 25-minute news capsule was exhibited in *haats* using projector. Urvashi Butalia (1993) highlighted the contribution of Cendit – a Delhi Based group and Self-employed Women’s Association (SEWA), a woman’s group based in Ahmedabad. Cendit on one hand was making videos for women keeping their way of story-telling (Swang) and modeling them in the video so that the video was not alien to them. On the other hand, SEWA, a large trade union of women workers in the informal sector in Gujarat were given training in video production which empowered them to shoot their own routine issues and exhibit them.

Social campaign videos are still shown in cinema halls and on television but digital media has given it a new impetus.

18.4.4 Community Radio

All India Radio has a wide network of radio stations connecting the urban and rural parts of the country. Being a public service broadcaster it incorporates

regional and people-centric programming. While private radio stations are entirely devoted to entertainment. Community Radio Stations (CRS) fill this gap created by public and private radio stations and emerge as an effective alternative broadcast medium and as the name suggests, the CRS serve a certain community.

CRS operate in an area of 5-10 km radius and aim to function for the betterment of the society by democratising information. The CRS are largely owned and operated by Universities, NGOs, independent media practitioners and media groups (which are not part of any big corporate). They broadcast content which is useful for the people residing in that community and highlight social issues ignored by the mainstream radio stations. Community radio programming is aimed at social development keeping the information needs of the community of that area in mind.

The Community Radio Guidelines 2006 stress that “the programmes of community radio should be of immediate relevance to the community and focus should be on issues relating to education, health, environment, and agriculture and rural and community development. And fifty per cent of the content should be generated by the participation of local people in the community in local language and dialect”. For instance, discussions and debates in studio, phone-in programmes, traditional music promotion etc. The essence of such people generated content is that they know the pulse of the audience and can contribute in making a content rich programme. Though the content produced in all the media platforms discussed above may be amateurish but expresses the spirit of the alternative media. Thus, community radio can be termed as peoples’ medium which is for the people by the people and of the people.

In 1998, The Deccan Development Society (DDS), an NGO working with poor, rural, dalit women in the Zaheerabad area of Medak district in Andhra Pradesh, had set up a CRS with assistance from UNESCO. Gurgaon ki Awaaz Samudayik Radio Station is another CRS in Gurgaon (Delhi NCR) which caters to the marginalised sections, migrant labourers from different states and villagers in the corporate hub of Gurgaon. The content is produced by villagers in popular languages and dialects such as Hindi, Haryanvi and Bhojpuri. Music programmes of wide range are aired from musical to discussion and debates in chaupal style keeping in mind the needs and understanding of the marginalised sections in the area.

18.4.5 Citizen Journalism

The Indian broadcasting sector is now majorly dominated by the private players and corporate houses. The Government control has become less with the increase in 24X7 television news channels in past few decades but these private broadcasters also repress the alternative voices instead of articulating them. Dasu Krishnamoorthy, former journalist and academician (2003) in a post - “Defining alternative media in Indian context” stressed on the weakness of mainstream media of not fulfilling the role of mass communication and informing the society. He said that government and mainstream media both do not pay much heed to the public opinion and alternative media should provide training to its manpower against mainstream media rather than the government.

The citizen journalism related videos broadcast on the private national news channel can also be considered as alternative media. The CNN-IBN broadcasts a

special programme called Citizen Journalist wherein the video shot by common citizens of the country on any social issue or human rights violation etc. can be sent to the TV station which can telecast it, if found relevant. The issues picked up by citizens are generally related to their neighbourhood but also have relevance for other sections of society. These days many newspapers also publish a column contributed by citizen journalists and all these initiatives can be considered as the alternative media.

Activity- 2

Listen to community radio broadcast in your area for a week and analyse its content. In your opinion, is the community radio an alternative medium of information keeping in view the points discussed above?

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. Define citizen journalism.

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2. How community radio station is different from the mainstream radio station?

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18.5 NEW MEDIA AND ALTERNATIVE MEDIA

With the advent of New Media, the difference between the mass media, personal media and alternative media has blurred. New media can be considered as mass media as well as personal media; however, the proponents of alternative media consider new media as an important alternative media which allows people to voice their opinions. With the arrival of social media; also known as Web 2.0, it includes those websites which enable users to create and share content, the differing voices have got a new platform bringing about a sea change in the very concept of alternative media. Now one does not need to be part of any radical group or any student union, as a commoner too you can voice your differences with the system through blogs, social networking sites, micro blogging sites etc.

Alternative media very much involves the various mass media forms; it reaches the masses and generate asymmetrical interaction. Whereas the content of the

alternative media is ‘de-professional’; it is not presented professionally as it is in mass media. As you are aware, the mainstream media is run by highly skilled professionals whereas alternative media lacks skilled professionals. Therefore, the content is de-professional and the presentation of the content may not be up to the standard. This is considered to be one of the biggest weaknesses of the alternative media but this pushes it out of the clutches of dominant ideology and powerful interest groups. The alternative media aims to provide alternative views and serve the society by informing and educating the masses not by serving the needs and desires of the corporate sectors and pressure groups. It is in contrast with mass culture propagated by mass media and in addition to de-professional content, alternative media also has lower budgets and operational costs in comparison to mass media.

18.5.1 Independent New Websites

New Media as alternative media has recorded significant growth in the past decade. The reason behind this is low fixed cost involved in venturing in this media. It has lowered the entry barrier for the young entrepreneurs to start their own media shops. Moreover, it is the convergent point of all the media as it amalgamates print (text, pictures), radio (audio) and TV (video) into one which makes it more interactive. The instant nature of new media has diluted delayed feedback nature of the other mass media. Many freelance journalists have started their own websites which act as an alternative to the mainstream media. Some such websites are goodnewsindia.com, infochangeindia.com and Lokmanch a Hindi language website that voice dissent against the ruling class. Even Khabar Lahriya had launched its website <http://khabarlahariya.org> where they also upload videos, audios and pictures related to their news reports. Merinews.com, launched in 2006 is the India’s largest citizen based news portal which allows citizens to express their views on any topic. Its editorial team further scrutinises the reports submitted by the citizens and has started publishing its city specific tabloid.

Activity- 3

Compare the number of articles per day in an alternative media website and a main stream media website on the following parameters:

Parameters	Alternative Media Website	Mainstream Media Website
Education		
Health		
Human rights		
Gender		

18.5.2 Social Media as Alternative Media

Social media has provided platform to individual citizens to participate in contemporary debates and discussions. People now also rely on Twitter for breaking news than the news channels. To them, Twitter is the place where one gets different opinion that may not find a place in dominant mainstream media. Half a decade ago many important, controversial stories would have been buried by the mainstream media but now with the power of social media it is not easy to

suppress information.

Social media gives platform to the citizen to become a producer through their blogs, tweets, status updates, articles etc. Earlier it was difficult to think of owning one's own newspaper or television channel because of heavy fixed costs involved. But now the new media and especially social media have made it easier for the young journalists to become entrepreneurs.

You may ask the questions - how many people have access to social media? Is it still not an urban and elite-centric media? How many times has any rural centric issue become the most debatable issue on social media? Has it become a promotional tool lately? All these questions are relevant and at times social media does end up being a promotional tool rather than being a platform for discussion and debates. The credibility and authenticity of the content on the social media websites is also under question. At times, information uploaded in haste leads to serious consequences. There is a need to cross check the facts before completely believing them. Even if an individual uploads something on social media it is very important for the producer to be socially responsible and sensitive.

Egyptian Revolution is said to be one of the mass movement triggered by social media. In 2011, in Egypt, the socio-political-economic condition was extremely depressing that general masses with the help of social media shook the government in power. The mainstream media of Egypt was under the state control. People chose to voice their dissent through social media; Twitter and Facebook were used rigorously to organise mass agitations and demonstrations against the government at Tahrir Square which resulted in the resignation by Hosni Mubarak from presidency and the powers were transferred to the Armed forces of Egypt. Later, the Supreme Court convicted him to life imprisonment for the failure to stop killings during the first six days of Egyptian revolution-2011.

Closer home, **Anna Movement of 2011 or India Against Corruption (IAC)**, is credited to be one mass movement which was initially engineered by the social media of India later joined by the mainstream media and set the agenda for coming months. In December, 2012 the infamous Delhi gang rape in a bus led to media uproar and social media again became a tool to unite people for **Nirbhaya Movement**. This had pressurised the legislature to amend the rape law of the country. Yet another example of social media phenomena was the support to Jallikattu in January, 2017 in Tamil Nadu wherein numerous Tamilian supporters gathered at famous Marina Beach in Chennai to lend their support to save their tradition and culture. Jallikattu is a bull taming sport held during Pongal, it was banned by the Supreme Court. Large share of this movement goes to social media and mobile messaging applications.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1) List some issues involved in the use of social media.

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- 2) What is difference between independent news websites and social media?

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Activity-4

Make a Facebook Page as your 'neighbourhood alternative media'. Give a suitable name to the page along with a logo as profile picture and complementing cover picture. Write about the neglected but important issues regarding your surrounding which are generally ignored by the mainstream media. Post articles regularly with apt pictures and videos. You may ask your neighbours and Facebook friends to read and participate.

18.6 FUTURE OF ALTERNATIVE MEDIA

The future of alternative media depends upon on each one of us - users, journalists as well as media channels. It needs to be analysed whether journalism is aimed to serve the society and people through journalistic writings or the interests of corporate houses. P. Sainath says that he will participate in the mainstream media and raise pertinent issues as he does not want to make it easier for the corporate and will also continue his support for alternative media. It is important for the journalists to understand the roles and objectives of media and focus on the developmental and human rights issues.

Apart from the duty of journalists the future of alternative media also lies in future communicating mediums. In last one decade the new media has totally changed the way we communicate. Now not only journalists but the common person has also got an imperative tool to voice their dissent. As discussed in the previous section, New media has given very affordable medium like websites, blogs, micro blogs, social networking sites which can function even without the support of advertising. The future of alternative media lies in the way new media is used by the netizens and how the course of technology changes from here. With pocket internet and ipads people are now using web like never before though it is still accessed by the urban class and there is a strong need to reach out to the rural population.

One such example is of **CGNetSwara** founded in 2008 which uses technology wisely and has emerged as an important alternative medium of communication. CGNet stands for Central Gondwana Net, and *swara* means "voice" in Sanskrit. According to its website- "it is a voice-based portal, freely accessible via mobile phone that allows anyone to report and listen to stories of local interest. Reported stories are moderated by journalists and become available for playback online as well as over the phone". CGNetSwara discusses the issues related to the tribal community in Central Gondwana region which is neglected by the mainstream media.

According to a report in livemint.com “The portal comprises four components: callers, who give missed calls to the portal phone number to either report or listen to news; a server that returns the call and collects and stores the audio bytes; moderators, who publish the byte on the website; and website visitors, who can be either journalists from the mainstream media who want to cover a certain story, non-governmental organisations that want to extend support, urban activists who follow reported stories, or local authorities who want to address grievances”. The impact of this alternative medium is also visible at grassroots level; many of the caller problems are resolved as administration is forced to look into the matter, once it is highlighted by the citizens.

Radio Pitara, a start up, founded in 2016 utilises ICT for rural communication. It is a free of cost service wherein an individual needs to give a missed call on a toll free number from his/her mobile number and in return, they get a call back and information and entertainment based content is played.

Activity 5

Visit the websites of above organisations and analyse their activities from the perspective of alternative media.

18.7 LET US SUM UP

In this unit we defined the term alternative media “as a small-scale, independent, grass root media which encourage alternative discourse to highlight the issues concerning the marginalised sections”. We examined different forms of alternative media available at the grassroots level for addressing the information needs of people who do not have access to mainstream media or are unable to relate with it. We also looked at some new media platforms such as merinews.com, khabarlahriya.org, cgnetswara.org and social media platforms such as: Twitter and Facebook which give outlet to different point of views.

From the discussion a strong need for alternative media was traced to give impetus to grassroots journalism and highlight the issues of the marginalised sections. For facilitating development and aiming to be a pluralistic society; it is imperative that more such platforms are introduced. The mainstream media should also focus on such issues and resist the pressures of corporate houses, political parties and think beyond TRPs and advertisements. We need to find ways to marry technology with content generation and distribution so that the alternative media reaches out to a wider audience and becomes relevant and remains independent. More liberal and social thinkers are required to take the baton of alternative media forward.

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18.9 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. Alternative media can be defined as any media platform run by people for people and of the people.
2. Mainstream media is known as elite media since it is owned by powerful corporate houses which largely cater to the needs of the elite class.
3. The alternative and mainstream media mainly differ on the following areas:
 - a) Mission
 - b) Content generation
 - c) Content distribution
 - d) Budget and operational cost (Advertisements, subscription cost)
 - e) News as commodity v/s social good
 - f) Role of gatekeepers

Check Your Progress 2

1. Citizen journalism is a platform promoted by private television news channels and newspapers wherein citizens report about any incident in their neighbourhood with a video footage or photograph with a small write-up. This platform has been adopted by new media as well.
2. Community radio stations mainly differ on following parameters:

Parameters	Community Radio Station	Mainstream Radio Station
Coverage	5-10 km	Very wide
Ownership	NGO/ University/ Individuals/group	Corporate/ Government
Content	Community specific, locally produced, Focus on infotainment	Entertainment based (private radio); Infotainment (public radio)
Target Group	Community	Masses
Advertisements	Negligible	Largely runs on advertising revenue
Size	Small group	Large organisations

Check Your Progress 3

1. Limited access, largely urban and elite centric, use as promotional tool, credibility and authenticity of the content are some of the issues involved in the use of social media.
2. Some differences between independent news website and social media are enumerated below:

Parameters	Independent News Websites	Social Media
Ownership	Individual/small groups	Owned by big groups/ companies
Content	News (focus on news filtered by mainstream media)	Can be about anything
Reach	Masses	Limited to followers/ Network
Content Producer	Professionals	Users
Use	Information, Education	Information, Entertainment, Education, Promotion
Engagement level	Low	High